

God's Dispensation Versus Differing Teachings

Scripture Reading: 1 Tim. 1:1-17

With this message we begin a series of Life-study Messages on 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, Titus, and Philemon. In previous Life-studies we have covered six books written by Paul: Romans, Hebrews, Ephesians, Colossians, Galatians, and Philippians. In these six books the basic and crucial truths concerning Christ and the church are revealed. The other four Epistles written by Paul are 1 and 2 Corinthians and 1 and 2 Thessalonians.

Of the fourteen Epistles written by Paul, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, Romans, and Hebrews are very basic and may be regarded as a group. First Timothy, 2 Timothy, Titus, and Philemon may also be considered a group. We believe that the arrangement of the books in the New Testament is according to the Lord's sovereignty. In this sovereign arrangement, the four books of 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, Titus, and Philemon are put together as a group.

Perhaps you are wondering how the other four of Paul's Epistles — 1 and 2 Corinthians and 1 and 2 Thessalonians — relate to the first two groups of writings. The first group, composed of six books, contains the basic revelation concerning Christ and the church, whereas the second group, composed of four books, deals with God's economy regarding the church. This group covers the dispensation of God with respect to the church. First and 2 Corinthians strengthen both of these groups of Epistles. In these two books we see some further and richer revelation concerning Christ and the church. On the one hand, in 1 and 2 Corinthians we have further riches of Christ; on the other hand, these books strengthen the economy of God concerning the church. Then what about 1 and 2 Thessalonians? In these Epistles Paul shows us our hope, the hope of glory, that is, the appearing of our dear Lord Jesus Christ.

I. The purpose of the four Epistles

A. First Timothy — to unveil God's dispensation concerning the church

First Timothy unveils to us God's dispensation concerning the church. It is not easy to present such a brief yet all-inclusive summary of this book. Only when we dig into the depths of this Epistle do we realize that this is the subject. If we get into the depths of this book, we shall see that it can be summarized as a book which speaks of God's dispensation, His New Testament economy, concerning the church.

In 1:4 Paul uses the marvelous term "God's dispensation." This dispensation is an economical administration. Hence, it refers to God's economy. God's economy is revealed in four expressions found in 1 Timothy 3: Great is the mystery of godliness; God was manifested in the flesh; the church is the house of the living God; the church is the pillar and base of the truth. God's dispensation is related to the great mystery of godliness, to the manifestation of God in the flesh, and to the church as both the house of the living God and the pillar and base of the truth. When God's dispensation is put together with these four matters, we see that 1 Timothy does in fact reveal God's economy concerning the church.

B. Second Timothy — to inoculate the church against the decline

The purpose of 2 Timothy is to inoculate the church against the decline. On the one hand, an inoculation is positive; on the other hand, it is negative, for it indicates that we need to be protected from a disease that could kill us. Paul's purpose in writing 2 Timothy was to inoculate the church against decline, degradation, and deterioration.

C. Titus — to maintain the order of the church

The purpose of the book of Titus is to maintain the order of the church. It was written to assure that a local church would have a proper order.

The unveiling of God's dispensation concerning the church in 1 Timothy, the inoculation against the decline of the church in 2 Timothy, and the maintaining of the order of the church in Titus are three aspects of one purpose: that is, to preserve the church as the proper expression of the Triune God, as symbolized by the golden lampstands in the ultimate portion of the divine revelation (Rev. 1:12, 20). For the accomplishment of this purpose, the following basic and crucial things are stressed repeatedly in these three books:

- 1) The faith, the contents of the complete gospel according to God's New Testament economy; hence, it is objective, as mentioned in 1 Tim. 1:19; 2:7; 3:9; 4:1, 6; 5:8; 6:10, 12, 21; 2 Tim. 2:18; 3:8; 4:7; Titus 1:13.
- 2) The truth, the reality of the contents of the faith, as mentioned in 1 Tim. 2:4, 7; 3:15; 4:3; 6:5; 2 Tim. 2:15, 18, 25; 3:7, 8; 4:4; Titus 1:1, 14.
- 3) Healthy teaching, in 1 Tim. 1:10; 2 Tim. 4:3; Titus 1:9; 2:1 healthy words, in 1 Tim. 6:3; 2 Tim. 1:13 healthy speech, in Titus 2:8 healthy in the faith and in faith, in Titus 1:13; 2:2. All these are related to the condition of life.
- 4) Life, the eternal life of God, in 1 Tim. 1:16; 2, 6:12, 19 Timothy 1:1, 10; Titus 1:2; 3:7.
- 5) Godliness, a living that is the expression of God, as mentioned in 1 Tim. 2:2, 10 (godly); 1 Tim. 3:16; 4:7, 8; 5:4; 6:3, 5, 6, 11; 2 Tim. 3:5, 12 (godly); Titus 1:1; 2:12 (godly). The opposite, ungodliness, is mentioned in 1 Tim. 1:9 (ungodly); 2 Tim. 2:16; Titus 2:12.
- 6) Faith, our act of believing in the gospel, in God, and in His word and deed; hence, it is subjective, as mentioned in 1 Tim. 1:2, 4, 5, 14, 19; 2:15; 3:13; 4:12; 6:11; 2 Tim. 1:5, 13; 2:22; 3:10, 15; Titus 1:1, 4; 2:2; 3:15.
- 7) Conscience, the leading part of our spirit, which justifies or condemns our relationships with God and with man, as mentioned in 1 Tim. 1:5, 19; 3:9; 4:2; 2 Tim. 1:3; Titus 1:15.

The faith equals the economy, the household administration, the dispensation, of God. The truth is the contents, the reality, of the faith according to God's economy. Healthy teachings, healthy words, and healthy speech are the ministry of the truth, ministering to people the reality of the divine truths. Eternal life is the means and power to carry out the divine realities of the faith. Godliness is a living that expresses the divine reality, an expression of God in all His riches. Faith (subjective) is the response to the truth of the faith (objective), receiving and participating in the divine realities. Conscience is a test and check to preserve us in the faith.

D. Philemon — an illustration of the believers' equal status in the new man

Philemon does not seem to be related to 1 and 2 Timothy and Titus. According to many Bible teachers, these three books are called pastoral Epistles, books that give instructions on how to pastor, shepherd, a church. Because the term pastoral as applied to these books is too shallow, I prefer not to use it. I admit, however, that there is an element of pastoring, of shepherding, in these books. But it is altogether too superficial to speak of them as pastoral Epistles. If we look into the depths of these books and realize that they speak respectively of God's dispensation concerning the church, inoculation against the decline of the church, and the maintenance of the order of the church, we shall realize that Philemon should be put together with them.

In Philemon we have an illustration of the believers' equal status in the new man. Although Philemon was a master, and Onesimus was a slave, they shared an equal status in the new man. As we shall see, Onesimus ran away from his master, but was saved through Paul in prison. Then Paul sent him back to Philemon not as a slave, but as a dear brother in Christ. Therefore, here we see an illustration of the equal status of all believers in the new man. If we put this Epistle together with 1 and 2 Timothy and Titus, we shall know how to have a proper local church life.

The title of this message is "God's Dispensation versus Differing Teachings." Very few Bible readers have seen this point in chapter one of 1 Timothy. But in this chapter there is the matter that God's dispensation is versus differing teachings. What is the focus of God's revelation, the focal point of God's economy, His dispensation? God's economy is to dispense Himself in Christ through the Spirit into His chosen people so that they may have the divine life and nature to be Christ's Body, the new man, the church, to express God in the universe. This is the crucial point.

The problem among Christians throughout the centuries has always been the differing teachings versus God's revelation. Some may argue that when they teach people to be immersed, they teach according to God's revelation. Although this may be true, immersion is not the main point of the divine revelation. The crucial point is not related to immersion, to whether we use wine or grape juice at the Lord's table, or to whether we believe in a rapture that is tribulation, post-tribulation, or mid-tribulation. Neither is the focal point of God's economy the huge image in Daniel 2 or the beasts in Revelation 13. How pitiful that Christians have argued over the type of water used in baptism, but have altogether neglected God's dispensation! It is vital for us to see that God's economy is God's dispensing of Himself as the wonderful Triune God — the Father, the Son, and the Spirit — into His chosen ones so that, having His very life and nature, they may become His many sons, the members of Christ, to manifest Him in the universe. This is the central revelation in the Scriptures; it is what the Bible speaks of as God's dispensation.

There were some during Paul's time who were teaching differently, just as there are today. They were teaching things that were versus God's dispensation. However, Peter, John, James, Paul, and the rest of the apostles preached the same thing — Christ and the church. Although the apostles were many, their ministry was one. We should never think that Peter, John, James, and Paul taught differently from one another. No, they all taught Christ and the church.

In the four Gospels one Person is revealed through four biographies. These biographies are written from different angles, but they do not reveal more than one Person. All four reveal the same Person, the Lord Jesus Christ. Because this wonderful Person has a Body, beginning with Acts and continuing through to the end of the New Testament, we see the Body of this Person. Again I say, all the apostles preached and taught the same thing, Christ and the church.

Because the apostles taught and preached Christ and the church, they all had one ministry. For this reason, Paul could say, "We have this ministry" (2 Cor. 4:1). The apostles were many, but they had received just one ministry. In chapter one of Acts there is a further indication that all the apostles were in one and the same ministry (v. 17). Any so-called ministry that is different from the ministry of Paul and the other apostles is actually not a ministry at all; it is a different teaching. According to the New Testament, the one ministry is to minister Christ to God's chosen people so that the church may be formed. This is God's economy, and it is versus all manner of differing teachings. God's economy certainly is not a matter of head covering, foot-washing, and regulations about eating or the keeping of days. God's dispensation is versus these differing teachings.

II. Introduction

A. Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus

Paul opens 1 Timothy with the words, "Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus, according to the command of God our Savior and of Christ Jesus our hope." It was according to the command of God and of Christ that Paul became an apostle. In his earlier Epistles, he told us that he was an apostle through the will of God (1 Cor. 1:1; 2 Cor. 1:1; Eph. 1:1; Col. 1:1). The command of God is a definite expression, a further direction, of the will of God.

God our Savior (1 Tim. 1:1; 4:10; Titus 2:13) and our Savior God (1 Tim. 2:3; Titus 1:3; 2:10; 3:4) are titles particularly ascribed to God in these three books, which take God's salvation as a strong base for the teachings concerning God's New Testament economy (1:15-16; 2:4-6; 2 Tim. 1:9-10; 2:10; 3:15; Titus 2:14; 3:5-7). It was according to the command of such a saving God, a Savior God, not according to the command of the law-giving God, a demanding God, that Paul became an apostle.

In 1:1 Paul speaks of "Christ Jesus our hope." Christ Jesus is not only God's Anointed (Christ) to be our Savior (Jesus) that we may be saved to gain the eternal life of God, but also our hope to bring us into the full blessing and enjoyment of this eternal life. The hope of eternal life revealed in Titus 1:2 as the base and condition of Paul's apostleship, and the blessed hope revealed in Titus 2:13, which is the appearing we are waiting for of the glory of the great God and our Savior, are all wrapped up with the Person of God's Messiah, our Savior. Hence, He Himself is our hope, the hope of glory (Col. 1:27). It was according to the command not only of our Savior God, but also of the One Who has saved us with eternal life and will bring us into the glory of this life, that Paul became an apostle. His command is of the eternal life and is to be fulfilled by the eternal life, in contrast to the command of the law-giving God, which was of letters and which was to be fulfilled by human effort, without the supply of eternal life.

B. To Timothy, genuine child in faith

In verse 2 Paul continues his word of introduction: "To Timothy, genuine child in faith: grace, mercy, peace, from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord." In Greek the name Timothy is timotheos, composed of time, meaning honor, and theos, meaning God. Thus, it means to honor God. Timothy became a genuine child of Paul, not by natural birth, but in faith, that is, in the sphere and element of faith; not naturally, but spiritually.

III. God's dispensation versus differing teachings

A. Differing teachings

In verse 3 Paul says, "Even as I urged you, when I was going into Macedonia, to remain in Ephesus in order that you might charge certain ones not to teach differently." Paul's word about "going into Macedonia" must refer to his travels after his liberation from the first imprisonment in Rome. Probably he wrote this Epistle from Macedonia, which is made up of what is today northern Greece and southern Bulgaria.

In verse 3 Paul refers to "certain ones." These were dissenting ones, as mentioned in verse 6 and in Galatians 1:7; 2:12.

To teach differently was to teach myths, unending genealogies (v. 4), and the law (vv. 7-8), all of which were vain talking (v. 6) and differed from the apostles' teaching centered upon Christ and the church.

Paul's Epistles are the completion of the divine revelation concerning God's eternal purpose and economy (Col. 1:25). His ministry completes the revelation concerning the all-inclusive Christ and His universal Body, the church as His fullness to express Him. Concerning the church as the Body of Christ, there are two sides: life and practice. From Romans through 2 Thessalonians, a full revelation is given concerning the life of the church, including its nature, responsibility, and function. Now, from 1 Timothy through Philemon, a detailed revelation concerning the practice of the church is presented. This pertains to the administration and shepherding of a local church. For this the first thing needed is to terminate the differing teachings of the dissenters, which distract the saints from the central line and ultimate goal of God's New Testament economy (vv. 4-6). The differing teachings in 1:3-4, 6-7; 6:3-5, 20-21, and the heresies in 4:1-3, are the seed, the source, of the church's decline, degradation, and deterioration dealt with in the second book.

1. Myths

In verse 4 Paul continues, “Nor to occupy themselves with myths and unending genealogies, which give occasion for questionings rather than God’s dispensation which is in faith.” The Greek word rendered “myths” in this verse is *muthos*. The same word is translated tales in 4:7 and fables in 2 Timothy 4:4. It refers to words, speeches, and conversations concerning such things as rumors, reports, stories (true or false), and fictions. It might include Jewish stories of miracles and rabbinical fabrications. They were the profane and old-womanish tales (4:7) and Jewish myths (Titus 1:14). The Jewish myths may have been the seed of Gnostic mythologies.

2. Unending genealogies

The “unending genealogies” mentioned in this verse probably refer to Old Testament genealogies adorned with fables (Titus 3:9).

3. Giving occasion for questions

The myths and unending genealogies give occasion for questionings and vain talking rather than God’s dispensation.

4. Vain talking

The myths and the unending genealogies give rise to vain talking and cause people to misaim from the goal of the charge of love. In verses 5 and 6 Paul says, “But the goal of the charge is love out of a pure heart, and a good conscience, and unfeigned faith; from which things some, having misaimed, have turned aside to vain talking.” The charge in verse 5 refers to the charge mentioned in verse 3. The differing teachings of the dissenting ones in verse 3 caused envy and discord among the believers. Such envy and discord were contrary to love, the goal of the apostle’s charge. To carry out the apostle’s charge, love, which is out of a pure heart, a good conscience, and unfeigned faith, is needed.

A pure heart is a single heart without mixture, seeking the Lord only and taking the Lord as the unique goal. A good conscience is a conscience without offense (Acts 24:16). Unfeigned faith, connected with faith in verse 4, is faith without pretense or hypocrisy, that purifies the heart (Acts 15:9) and works through love (Gal. 5:6). In order to deal with the differing teachings when the trend of the church is toward decline, all these attributes are required. They are necessary if we are to have a pure, true, and genuine love.

5. The law

In verse 7 Paul refers to law teachers: “Desiring to be law teachers, understanding neither what they are saying, nor concerning what they confidently affirm.” Law teachers, teaching people what to do and what not to do, are different from the minister of Christ (4:6), who ministers His riches to others. According to this verse, those who desire to be law teachers confidently affirm certain things. The Greek for confidently can also be rendered strongly or emphatically. The same word is used in Titus 3:8.

According to verses 8 through 10, the law is good if used lawfully. Paul says that the “law is not enacted for a righteous man, but for the lawless and unruly, for the ungodly and sinners, for the unholy and profane, for smiters of fathers and smiters of mothers, for manslayers, for fornicators, homosexuals, kidnappers, liars, perjurers, and if there be any other thing opposed to healthy teaching.”

The words “healthy teaching” imply the matter of life. Anything that is healthy refers to the health of life. The sound teaching of the apostles, which is according to the gospel of the glory of God, ministers healthy teaching as the supply of life to people, either nourishing them or healing them. In contrast, the differing teachings of the dissenting ones in verse 3 sow the seeds of death and poison into others. Any teaching that distracts people from the center and goal of God’s New Testament economy is not healthy.

B. God’s dispensation

In Greek the words “God’s dispensation” in 1:4 also mean God’s household economy (Eph. 1:10; 3:9). This is God’s household administration to dispense Himself in Christ into His chosen people, that He may have a house, a household, to express Himself, which household is the church, the Body of Christ (1 Tim. 3:15). The apostle’s ministry was centered upon this economy of God (Col. 1:25; 1 Cor. 9:17), whereas the differing teachings of the dissenting ones were used by God’s enemy to distract His people from this. This divine economy must be made fully clear to the saints in the administration and shepherding of a local church.

My burden is altogether centered on God’s economy. This has been my burden for more than forty years. During the years I have been in this country, I have not taught anything other than God’s dispensation.

1. God’s household economy

God’s dispensation is His household economy. According to the Bible, God does not first want to have a kingdom. Rather, He first wants a house, a family. Once He has a family, His family will spontaneously become His kingdom. If He is not able to secure a family, a household, a house, He will not be able to have a kingdom. Thus, God’s dispensation is first a matter of His household economy, or family economy.

2. God’s household administration

Second, God’s dispensation is His household administration to dispense Himself in Christ into His chosen people that He might have a house, a household, the church, the Body of Christ, to express Himself.

3. The focus of the apostle Paul’s ministry

God’s dispensation was the focus of the Apostle Paul’s ministry (Col. 1:25; 1 Cor. 9:17).

4. In faith

In verse 4 Paul tells us that God’s dispensation is in faith. The dispensing of God into us is altogether by faith. The dispensation of God is a matter in faith, that is, in the sphere and element of faith, in God through Christ. Faith may be in contrast to questionings. God’s economy to dispense Himself into His chosen people is not in the natural realm, nor in the work of law, but in the spiritual sphere of the new creation through regeneration by faith in Christ (Gal. 3:23-26). By faith we are born of God to be His sons, partaking of His life and nature to express Him. By faith we are put into Christ to become the members of His Body, sharing all that He is for His expression. This is God’s dispensation according to His New Testament economy, carried out in faith.

We need to be deeply impressed with the meaning of faith in the New Testament. We have spoken much about this in our Life-studies of Romans, Hebrews, and Galatians. Faith is firstly God being the Word spoken to us. We have God and then God as the Word spoken. Through the Word of God and by the Spirit of God we are infused with God in Christ. As a result, something rises up within us. This is faith. Faith then works in us to bring us into an organic union with the Triune God. Through this organic union, God is continually transfused and infused into us. As a result, we have the divine life and the divine nature to become God’s sons, members of Christ, and parts of the new man. As a totality we become the house of God, the Body of Christ, and the new man. This is God’s dispensation in faith.

5. According to the gospel of the glory of the blessed God

God’s dispensation is “according to the gospel of the glory of the blessed God” (v. 11). Have you heard this expression before? Many have heard of the gospel of grace, the gospel of forgiveness, the gospel of justification, and the gospel of regeneration, but not the gospel of glory. This gospel not only brings good news concerning forgiveness of sins and justification by faith; the gospel of glory is the gospel of God’s dispensation. Glory is God expressed. Thus, the gospel of glory is the gospel of the expressed God; it is a gospel which expresses God’s glory.

The “gospel of the glory of the blessed God” is an excellent expression. It refers to God’s dispensation mentioned in verse 4. The gospel with which Paul was entrusted is the effulgence of the glory of the blessed God. This gospel, by dispensing God’s life and nature in Christ into His chosen people, shines forth His glory, in which He is blessed among His people. This is the commission and ministry the apostle received of the Lord (v. 12). This should be commonly taught and preached in a local church.

In verse 12 Paul says, “I give thanks to Him Who empowers me, Christ Jesus our Lord, because He has counted me faithful, appointing me to the ministry.” The Lord not only appointed the apostle to the ministry and commissioned him with the dispensation of God outwardly, but also empowered him inwardly to carry out His ministry and fulfill His commission. This is altogether a matter of life in the Spirit.

6. A pattern under God’s dispensation

In 1:13-17 we see a pattern under God’s dispensation.

a. The foremost sinner

Paul says that he was a foremost sinner (vv. 15-16). He was a blasphemer of God, a persecutor of man, and an insulting, destructive person with respect to the church. In verse 13 he says of himself, “Who formerly was a blasphemer and a persecutor and an insulting destructive person; but I obtained mercy because being ignorant I acted in unbelief.” A blasphemer is one who blasphemes God, and a persecutor is one who persecutes man. Saul of Tarsus, a strict Pharisee (Acts 22:3; Phil. 3:4-5), could never have blasphemed God. But he had spoken evil of the Lord Jesus. Now he confesses that this was blaspheming. This indicates that he believed in the deity of Christ.

Saul of Tarsus persecuted the church in an insulting, destructive way (Acts 22:4; Gal. 1:13, 23), just as the insulting Jews persecuted the Lord Jesus.

Paul also says that he was ignorant and acted in unbelief. To be ignorant means to be in darkness, and unbelief comes from blindness. Saul of Tarsus was in darkness and acted in blindness when he opposed God’s New Testament economy.

b. Having obtained mercy

In verse 13 Paul testifies that he obtained mercy. Saul, a blasphemer and persecutor, first obtained mercy and then received grace (v. 14). Mercy reaches farther to the unworthy one than grace. Because Paul was a blasphemer of God and a persecutor of man, God’s mercy reached him first rather than the Lord’s grace.

c. Favored with the Lord’s grace

Verse 14 continues, “And the grace of our Lord superabounded with faith and love in Christ Jesus.” The Lord’s grace, following God’s mercy, visited Saul of Tarsus and not only abounded, but superabounded in him with faith and love in Christ. Faith and love are the product of the Lord’s grace. Mercy and grace come to us from the Lord; faith and love return to the Lord from us. This is a spiritual traffic between the Lord and us. Faith is for us to receive the Lord (John 1:12), and love is for us to enjoy the Lord whom we have received (John 14:21, 23; 21:15-17).

d. Saved by Christ Jesus

In verse 15 Paul declares, “Faithful is the word and worthy of all acceptance, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the foremost.” Christ came into the world to be our Savior by incarnation (John 1:14). He was God incarnated that He may save us through His death and resurrection in His human body. This should be constantly announced as the gospel, the glad tidings, in a local church.

e. Believing on Christ unto eternal life

In verse 16 Paul speaks of believing on Christ unto eternal life. The uncreated life of God is the ultimate gift and topmost blessing given by God to those who believe on Christ.

f. To display all the longsuffering of Christ and to be a pattern to all the believers

In verse 16 Paul says, “But because of this I obtained mercy, that in me, the foremost, Jesus Christ might display all His longsuffering for a pattern to them who are about to believe on Him unto eternal life.” Saul of Tarsus as the foremost among sinners became a pattern to sinners, who can be visited by God’s mercy and saved by the Lord’s grace.

7. Honor and glory to the King of the ages

In verse 17 Paul says, “Now to the King of the ages, incorruptible, invisible, the only God, be honor and glory unto the ages of the ages, Amen!” This word needs to be understood in relation to the decline of the church. When Paul was in prison, the churches began to decline, and the situation was very disappointing. Many were discouraged. Even some of Paul’s co-workers left him. But he had a strong faith with an absolute assurance that the very God in whom he believed, the One who had entrusted him with the gospel of glory, is the King of the ages. He never changes. No earthly king can be called the King of the ages. Caesar was a temporary ruler, but how different is our God! The God whom Paul served truly is the King of the ages. This means that He is King of eternity. He never changes; He always remains the same.

Everything except God is corruptible. The church may decline, deteriorate, and become degraded, but God is incorruptible. Paul also says that God is invisible. God is powerful, everlasting, incorruptible, and also invisible. We cannot see Him. Certain terms ascribed to God in this verse are used only in this book. With Paul, we need to use these words to praise God. I would encourage someone to write a suitable melody for the singing of this verse. In a living, released way, we need to declare, “Now to the King of the ages, incorruptible, invisible, the only God, be honor and glory unto the ages of the ages, Amen!”

Faith and a Good Conscience Needed for the Keeping of the Faith

Scripture Reading: 1 Tim. 1:18-20

In the foregoing message we saw from 1 Tim. 1:1-17 that God's dispensation is versus differing teachings. In this message we shall consider 1:18-20, verses which indicate that faith and a good conscience are needed for the keeping of the faith.

I. A charge committed by the apostle to his child Timothy

In 1:18 Paul says, "This charge I commit to you, child Timothy, according to the prophecies previously made concerning you, that in them you might war the good warfare." To what charge is Paul referring here? In answering this question we must observe the principle that in understanding a sentence, a phrase, or even a word of the Bible, we need to consider the context, not only of the paragraph in which the verse is found, but sometimes of the entire book or even of the whole Bible. With this principle as our basis, we need to consider Paul's use of the word charge in verse 18 in the context of the chapter as a whole. The charge here covers the main points presented in the previous seventeen verses. On the positive side, the main point of these verses is God's dispensation; on the negative side, it is the differing teachings. Hence, the charge given by the apostle to his spiritual son concerns the dispensation of God positively and the differing teachings negatively.

A. According to the prophecies previously made concerning Timothy

In verse 18 Paul says that he committed the charge to Timothy "according to the prophecies previously made" concerning him. It may be that some prophetic intimations were made concerning Timothy when he was admitted into the ministry (Acts 16:1-3). Perhaps the elders in the church which recommended Timothy to Paul laid hands on him. At that time prophecies might have been spoken concerning him.

B. To war the good warfare

Speaking of these prophecies, Paul tells Timothy, "In them you might war the good warfare." To war the good warfare is to war against the differing teachings of the dissenters and to carry out God's dispensation (v. 4) according to the apostle's ministry concerning the gospel of grace and eternal life for the glory of the blessed God (vv. 11-16).

C. In the prophecies

Paul charged Timothy to war the good warfare in the prophecies. This means in the sphere, support, and confirmation of the prophecies.

At this point we need to see something concerning the grouping and the timing of Paul's Epistles. Although Philemon is grouped with 1 and 2 Timothy and Titus, it was actually written earlier, during Paul's first imprisonment. Paul was imprisoned the first time because of the Jews, not because of persecution carried out by the Roman Empire. We know from Acts that Paul appealed to Caesar and this caused him to be sent to Rome, where he was imprisoned. During his first imprisonment, Paul wrote four books: Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, and Philemon. Thus, according to the time it was written, Philemon should be grouped with Colossians, Philippians, and Ephesians; however, in content it should be grouped, not with these Epistles, but with 1 and 2 Timothy and Titus. Philemon was written not long before Paul's release from prison. In the book of Philippians he expressed his expectation that soon he would be released and visit the churches. Not long afterward, Paul's expectation was fulfilled. Having been released, he traveled to Ephesus, where Timothy was, and from Ephesus he went into Macedonia. From Macedonia Paul wrote the first Epistle to Timothy. Then from Macedonia he went to Nicopolis, where he wrote the Epistle to Titus. First Timothy and Titus, therefore, were written after Paul's release from his first imprisonment. After approximately a year, Caesar Nero suddenly began to persecute Christians. At that time, Paul was accused of being the outstanding leader among the Christians. He was arrested and imprisoned again, this time due to Nero's persecution. From prison, he wrote the second Epistle to Timothy. In chapter four he indicates to his dear child Timothy that he was ready to depart, to be martyred, to be poured out as a drink offering.

During Paul's first imprisonment, the churches were tested. This test showed that decline and degradation had set in. This decline was altogether due to differing teachings, teachings that were different from the ministry. This was the reason Paul charged Timothy to war a good warfare.

Throughout the centuries, the degradation and decline of the church has had one source: teachings which differ from the ministry of the apostles. In Acts 2:42 we see that at the beginning of the church life, the believers continued in the teachings of the apostles. These teachings were the ministry. What the apostles taught and preached was nothing other than Christ and the church. They preached a Christ who had been incarnated, crucified, resurrected, and ascended in order that, as resurrection life, He might be imparted into His believers to produce the church. This is the focal point of the teaching of the apostles, and it is crucial for us to see it. No doubt, in the Bible there are teachings concerning many things. However, the focus of the ministry of the apostles was the incarnated, crucified, resurrected, ascended, and glorified Christ to be our Savior, our life, and everything to us so that we may become His Body, the church. This is the vital focus of the New Testament revelation, and this is God's economy.

We need to contact the Word and receive God by the Spirit through the Word. Then we shall have faith. By coming to the Word, we are infused with God, and spontaneously faith operates within us to bring us into an organic union with God. The more we enjoy God's infusion, the more we become one with Him. However, this vital matter has been lost for centuries. Knowing the importance of this, Paul charged Timothy to fight a good fight, to war a good warfare.

On the one hand, Timothy was to war against the differing teachings of the dissenters. On the other hand, he was to carry out God's dispensation according to the apostle's ministry. If we wish to carry out God's dispensation, we must do it not according to the teachings of traditional Christianity nor according to systematic theology, but according to the apostle's ministry.

Furthermore, God's dispensation concerns the gospel of grace and eternal life. These are two basic elements in the gospel. This gospel is for the glory of the blessed God; it is for the expression, the manifestation, of the blessed God.

When Paul was in prison the first time, dissenters rose up to teach differently. These differing teachings were the seed of the church's decline. Paul realized the situation even while he was in prison. We know this by the contents of books such as Colossians and Philippians. Especially in Colossians we see that certain isms — Judaism, Gnosticism, asceticism — had crept into the church life. These differing teachings caused dissension and decline. Thus, Paul charged his faithful co-worker to fight the good fight against the differing teachings and fight for God's dispensation.

Today we also must be on the alert for differing teachings. Throughout the centuries, the church has been poisoned and corrupted by such teachings. If we are not on guard, differing teachings may also cause damage to the Lord's recovery. In the past we have seen the damage caused by differing teachings propagated in a subtle, hidden way. This has helped the leading ones in many churches to learn the important lesson of being watchful for differing teachings. We must not allow any differing teachings to come into the Lord's recovery. The recovery is strictly for the carrying on of the ministry. By this I do not mean my ministry, but the ministry of the apostles, which began with Peter and is still being carried on today. All true apostles teach and preach the same thing, even the one thing — God's New Testament economy. The focus of our preaching and teaching is Christ and the church. To teach and preach God's economy concerning Christ and the church is to war a good warfare.

II. Holding faith and a good conscience

In verse 19 Paul continues, "Holding faith and a good conscience, which some thrusting away have become shipwrecked regarding the faith." This verse tells us how to war the good warfare. In order to war a good warfare, we must hold faith and a good conscience.

A. Faith, our believing act

The word faith in the expression "holding faith" refers to our believing act; hence, it denotes subjective faith. As we have indicated, this faith rises up in us when we come to the Word and are infused with God through the Word and by the Spirit. The subjective faith moves within us to bring about an organic union between us and the Triune God. In this union we receive the divine life and nature to become God's many sons and the many members of the Body of Christ, the new man, to be the corporate expression of the Triune God for eternity. We must war the good warfare by this kind of faith, not by trying to keep the law.

B. A good conscience

Along with faith, we also need a good conscience, a conscience without offense (Acts 24:16). A good conscience is a safeguard of Christian faith and life. Faith and a good conscience go together. Whenever there is an offense in our conscience, there will be a leakage, and our faith will leak away. A good conscience accompanying faith is needed for warring the good warfare against the dissenting teachings in a troubled local church.

C. Shipwrecked

It is difficult to say whether the relative pronoun "which" in verse 19 refers just to conscience or to both faith and conscience. It may refer to both, since subjective faith is closely related to the conscience. As we have pointed out, if we do not have a good conscience, we cannot have living faith. Likewise, if we do not have a living faith, we cannot have a good conscience. Faith and a good conscience can be compared to a married couple: faith is like a husband, and conscience is like a wife. Since subjective faith and a good conscience go together, I prefer to regard the relative pronoun here as having both faith and conscience as the antecedent. Faith comes from our contact with God and brings us into the organic union with God; conscience is the organ touched by God after we contact Him by faith.

By thrusting away faith and a good conscience, some "have become shipwrecked regarding the faith." This shows us the seriousness of thrusting away a good conscience. To keep faith and a good conscience is a safeguard for our Christian faith and life. The word shipwrecked implies that the Christian life and the church life are like a ship sailing on a stormy sea, needing to be safeguarded by faith and a good conscience.

Those who thrust away faith and a good conscience become shipwrecked regarding the faith. In this verse Paul speaks both of subjective faith, our act of believing, and of objective faith, those things in which we believe. In speaking of those who are shipwrecked regarding the faith, Paul has in mind the objective faith, the contents of the complete gospel according to God's New Testament economy.

In verse 20 Paul goes on to name two of those who have become shipwrecked regarding the faith: "Of whom is Hymenaeus and Alexander, whom I have delivered to Satan that they may be disciplined not to blaspheme." Hymenaeus was a heretical teacher (2 Tim. 2:17), and Alexander was an opposer, an attacker, of the apostle (2 Tim. 4:14-15).

It is worthy of note that here Paul mentions names. Being more careful or "spiritual" or "heavenly" than Paul, we may not be willing to mention names under any circumstances. God took the lead to mention the name of His enemy — Satan. God has never said, "My people, I have an enemy. But because I am so merciful, patient, and all-embracing, I don't want to expose him or mention his name, in hope that one day he will repent." As God has singled out the name of His enemy, Paul mentioned the names of Hymenaeus and Alexander.

Furthermore, Paul does not tell us in verse 20 that he has been praying for Hymenaeus and Alexander. He does not charge Timothy, "Timothy, learn of me to pray for those who injure you as I have been praying for Hymenaeus and Alexander." On the contrary, in 2 Timothy 4:14 Paul says, "Alexander the coppersmith did many evil things to me; the Lord will repay him according to his works."

Paul tells Timothy that he has delivered Hymenaeus and Alexander to Satan "that they may be disciplined not to blaspheme." How utterly different this is from saying that he committed them to the Lord's gracious hand that they may receive His mercy. Paul expected Satan to work for him to discipline Hymenaeus and Alexander.

First Timothy 1:20 is a most unusual verse dealing with a negative matter. Two people are named not by a backslidden brother but by the leading apostle. Furthermore, they are delivered not to God, nor to the church, nor to a spiritual person, but to Satan.

Paul delivered Hymenaeus and Alexander to Satan "that they may be disciplined not to blaspheme." Paul does not say "punished"; rather, he speaks of being disciplined. Discipline is somewhat different from punishment. When parents deal with their children, they may tell them that they are punishing them. However, that is not actually punishment; it is loving discipline. The discipline in verse 20 may refer to the destruction of the physical body (see 1 Cor. 5:5).

Through the carrying out of a certain discipline Hymenaeus and Alexander would learn not to blaspheme God, slander God's economy, nor damage the apostle's ministry. To deliver persons like Hymenaeus and Alexander to Satan is to exercise the authority that the Lord has given to the apostle and the church (Matt. 16:19; 18:18) for the administration of the church against Satan's evil plot.

Prayer to Carry Out God's Desire for Man's Salvation

Scripture Reading: 1 Tim. 2:1-7

A proper prayer life for a proper church life

In the first chapter of 1 Timothy Paul lays a good foundation to speak of the church life in a positive way. In 2:1 he goes on to say, "I exhort therefore, first of all, that petitions, prayers, intercessions, thanksgivings be made on behalf of all men." If we would have a proper church life, we must first have a prayer life. The leading ones, those who minister the Word in the church, should take the lead to have such a prayer life. A prayer ministry is the prerequisite for the administration and shepherding of a local church. Thus, Paul exhorts Timothy that petitions, prayers, intercessions, and thanksgivings be made on behalf of all men. This is the first word concerning the positive aspect of the church life Paul gives after speaking of God's economy and after charging Timothy to war the good warfare for God's economy. Timothy had to take the lead to have a prayer life.

A prerequisite for having a proper church life in the Lord's recovery today is to have a prayer life. A proper church is a praying church. A church that is without prayer is pitiful. Prayerlessness is a sin. All in the Lord's recovery must be prayerful and stand against the sin of prayerlessness. The elders in the churches must take up Paul's charge to "first of all" pray.

Of the fourteen Epistles written by Paul, ten were written to churches and four to individuals. Romans was written to all the believers in Rome, and Hebrews was written not to individuals, but to believing Hebrews addressed corporately. Ephesians, Philippians, Galatians, Colossians, 1 and 2 Corinthians, and 1 and 2 Thessalonians were all written to churches. However, the four Epistles of 1 and 2 Timothy, Titus, and Philemon were written to individuals. Some may think that these Epistles are not related to us because they were written to individuals. However, we should be today's Timothy, Titus, and Philemon. In particular, each individual saint needs to be a Timothy.

If we would be a Timothy, we must take the lead not to argue, gossip, or criticize, but to pray. Whenever we hear some news, good or bad, concerning a particular church, we should pray. Do not discuss the situation, do not gossip about it, and do not criticize. Just pray! Likewise, if you hear something about a saint or about an elder, pray for that one. The first requirement to have a proper church life is to pray. Oh, we all need to practice this! If we exercise ourselves to have a prayer life, the church will be living and uplifted. If some would be today's Timothys to take the lead to pray, the others will follow. This can be illustrated by the way a flock of sheep follows the few who take the lead. If you, as a Timothy, take the lead to pray, the congregation in your locality will follow.

Instead of talking so much and even instead of working so much, we should pray more. Should you hear that a saint is weak or backsliding, do not talk about that person, and do not criticize him. Moreover, do not immediately go to visit him. Instead, pray for him. Whether or not you should visit him depends on the Lord's leading. After you pray about the matter, if the Lord leads you to visit that one, simply follow the Lord and visit him. But do not do anything presumptuously. If the Lord does not lead you to visit a backsliding saint, you should not visit him on your own. It is possible that even in visiting the saints we may be presumptuous. Yes, visiting a backsliding saint is a presumptuous sin if it is done in ourselves apart from prayer and the Lord's leading. But if through our prayer the Lord definitely leads us to visit a certain one, that visitation will be effective.

We should also pray whenever we hear of problems among the saints. We should not presume that we are experienced and qualified to solve problems. Such an attitude is not only presumptuous; it is also blasphemous, for it is to consider ourselves as God. If we learn about a problem between brothers, we should bring this matter to the Lord in our prayer.

The first thing the elders should do in caring for the church is pray. Do not make decisions without praying. Do not either criticize someone or praise him without first praying for him. Before doing anything, we need to pray. Furthermore, our prayers should not be light or superficial; they must be thorough. Only after we have prayed for a matter thoroughly should we make a decision concerning it, not by ourselves independently, but in oneness with the Lord and according to His leading. If the elders practice in this way the church life in our locality will be uplifted and proper.

Brother Nee often told us that in reading the Bible we need to touch the spirit of the writer. The Bible in black and white letters can be likened to a human body, and the writer's spirit can be likened to the life, or to the spirit, in the body. Within the "body" of the Bible, there is the writer's spirit. If we touch Paul's spirit in 2:1-7, we shall sense his burden that those who take the lead in the church life must have a prayer life. In these verses Paul seems to be telling Timothy, "I have shown you a clear picture of God's economy and how it is versus different teachings. I have also pointed out to you that, in His mercy, the Lord has made me a pattern of His economy. I have also charged you solemnly to war the good warfare on behalf of God's economy. Now deep in my spirit is the burden to exhort you to pray. I exhort that petitions, prayers, intercessions, thanksgivings be made on behalf of all men. Do not think that teaching comes before prayer. No, prayer must be first, and teaching, second."

In 2:1 Paul mentions petitions, prayers, intercessions, and thanksgivings. Prayer is general, with the essence of worship and fellowship. Petitions are special and are for particular needs. The Greek word rendered "intercessions" means approach to God in a personal and confiding manner, that is, intervening, interfering, before God in others' affairs for their benefit. In addition, we must offer thanksgiving. Often when we hear good news about certain churches, elders, or saints, we praise them instead of giving thanks to God for them. If the situation in a certain church is good, it is because of God, not because of the church. Likewise, if a particular elder or saint is doing well, it also is because of God's grace. Therefore, instead of praising a church or a person, we should give thanks to God.

In mentioning petitions, prayers, intercessions, and thanksgivings, Paul's spirit was very burdened concerning the importance of prayer. He wanted his dear spiritual children to pray. Again and again I would emphasize the fact that we can have a proper church life only if we have a prayer life. I can testify that I have never prayed more than I have during the past several years. I can also testify that I have seen definite answers to my prayers. Recently, my activity was limited for a time so that I could rest and care for my health. When I heard about certain needs, I prayed for them. Perhaps the Lord limited me that He might impress me with the fact that prayer is more important than work. May we all learn the lesson that the way to have a good church life is to pray. This is crucial. If our talking is turned into praying, the church in our locality will be transformed.

Godliness and gravity

After pointing out that we should pray on behalf of all men, Paul goes on to say that we should pray “on behalf of kings and all who are in high position, that we may lead a tranquil and quiet life in all godliness and gravity.” A tranquil and quiet life is one that is peaceable, still, and without disturbance, not only outwardly in circumstances, but also inwardly in our heart and spirit, that we may have an enjoyable church life in godliness and gravity. Godliness is God-likeness; it is to be like God and to express Him. The Christian life should be a life which expresses God and bears God’s likeness in all things. Gravity is a qualification of human character which is worthy of utmost respect; it implies dignity and inspires and invites honor. Godliness is the expression of God; gravity is toward man. Our Christian life should express God toward man with an honorable character that invites man’s utmost respect.

Our savior God

Verse 3 says, “This is good and acceptable in the sight of our Savior God.” In this Epistle Paul emphasizes the Savior God. Hence, in this verse he speaks not of the God of grace, nor of the God of mercy, but of the Savior God, the God who saves us.

God’s desire

In verse 4 Paul says that God desires all men to be saved and come to the full knowledge of the truth. We should pray on behalf of all men because God our Savior desires all men to be saved and know the truth. Our prayer is required for the carrying out of God’s desire.

God desires all men not only to be saved, but also to have the full knowledge of the truth. Truth means reality, denoting all the real things revealed in God’s Word, which are mainly Christ as the embodiment of God and the church as the Body of Christ. Every saved person should have a full knowledge, a complete realization, of these things.

The object of the two Epistles to Timothy is to deal with the church’s decline. In the first Epistle the decline crept in subtly through differing teachings (1 Tim. 1:3), and in the second, it developed openly and became worse through the heresies (1 Tim. 2:16-18). To deal with such a decline the truth must be maintained. The first Epistle emphasizes that God desires all His saved ones to have the full knowledge of the truth and that the church is the pillar and base of the truth (1 Tim. 3:15). The second Epistle stresses that the word of the truth should be rightly unfolded (2 Tim. 2:15), and that the deviated ones should return to the truth (2 Tim. 2:25).

One mediator

In 1 Tim. 2:5 Paul continues, “For there is one God and one Mediator of God and men, the Man, Christ Jesus.” In this verse Paul explicitly says that there is one God. Although God is Triune — the Father, the Son, and the Spirit — He is still the one God, not three Gods, as mistakenly realized and believed by many Christians.

In this verse Paul also tells us that there is one Mediator of God and men. A mediator is a go-between. The one Mediator is the Man, Christ Jesus. The Lord Jesus was God from eternity (John 1:1). In time He became a man through incarnation (John 1:14). While He was living on earth as a man, He was also God (1 Tim. 3:16). After resurrection He was still man as well as God (Acts 7:56; John 20:28). Hence, He is the only One qualified to be the Mediator, the go-between, of God and men.

The testimony borne in its own times

Verse 6 says, “Who gave Himself a ransom on behalf of all, the testimony to be borne in its own times.” Christ gave Himself a ransom for the accomplishment of redemption for all men. This was necessary in order for Christ to be our Mediator. The Greek word for ransom means payment in recompense. He is qualified to be the Mediator between God and man, not only in His divine and human Person, but also in His redemptive work. Both His Person and work are unique.

In this verse Paul speaks of “the testimony to be borne in its own times.” This is in apposition to the preceding clause; that is, the fact that Christ gave Himself a ransom for all men becomes the testimony to be rendered in its own times. Whenever this fact is proclaimed, it is a testimony to be rendered to men in its own times. For example, when this fact was preached in Africa, that automatically became a testimony rendered to men in Africa in its own times. The preaching of the fact is always spontaneously a testimony of the fact. When Paul preached in Asia Minor, that was the testimony borne in its own times. The same was true when he received the Macedonian call and began to preach in eastern Europe. That was the proper time for the testimony to be declared there. Whenever the facts of Christ’s incarnation and death on behalf of all are proclaimed, that is the preaching, the testimony, borne in its own times.

Paul’s triple status

In verse 7 Paul concludes, “For which I was appointed a herald and an apostle (I speak the truth, I do not lie), a teacher of the nations in faith and truth.” A herald is a proclaimer of the gospel of Christ, an official reporter of God’s New Testament economy; an apostle is one sent by God with a divine commission to set up churches for God, an ambassador from God to the world for the carrying out of His purpose; and a teacher is a tutor who defines, explains, and teaches the contents of God’s eternal purpose and His New Testament economy. Paul had such a triple status and commission for the nations, the Gentiles.

Faith and truth

Paul had such a status in faith and truth. Faith here refers to the faith in Christ (Gal. 3:23-26), and truth refers to the reality of all the things revealed in the New Testament. This corresponds to 4:3, those who believe and “have fully known the truth.” It is in the sphere and element of this faith and truth, not of the law, types, and prophecies of the Old Testament, that Paul was appointed a herald, an apostle, and a teacher of the New Testament.

The principle of incarnation

The title of this message is “Prayer to Carry Out God’s Desire for Man’s Salvation.” Although God has such a desire, a heart, to save people, He can fulfill His desire only through the principle of incarnation. This means that He cannot save people directly; He must do it through us. Not even the angels have been appointed by God with such a commission for the carrying out of God’s desire. This commission has been entrusted only to man. For the carrying out of this commission, we need to pray. According to Acts 10, both Peter and Cornelius were praying. Peter was praying on the housetop, and Cornelius was praying in his house. From both sides, prayer ascended to the throne of God for the carrying out of God’s desire. By means of this prayer, God could accomplish His desire to save the Gentiles. The first Gentile household to be saved was that of Cornelius. This one example shows that our prayer is crucial for the carrying out of God’s desire for man’s salvation.

The Normal Life of the Brothers and Sisters in the Church

Scripture Reading: 1 Tim. 2:8-15

In this message we shall consider from 2:8-15 the normal life of the brothers and sisters in the church. After Paul charges Timothy to take the lead to have a prayerful life, he goes on to speak of this matter. In 2:8-15 Paul devotes one verse (v. 8) to the brothers and seven verses to the sisters (vv. 9-15). This indicates that if we are to have a proper church life, the sisters must bear a sevenfold burden, a sevenfold responsibility.

I. The brothers

A. Praying in every place

Concerning the brothers, Paul says in verse 8, “I will therefore that men pray in every place, lifting up holy hands, without wrath and reasoning.” In a local church the leading ones must have a prayer life, as they were charged in verses 1 and 2, to set an example of prayer for all the members to follow by praying always in every place. In Ephesians 6 Paul tells us to pray at every time, but here he says to pray in every place. Although it is possible for us to pray at every time, morning, afternoon, evening, and night, it may not be possible for us to pray in every place. The requirement to pray in every place is more demanding than that to pray at every time. If we can pray in every place, we can surely pray at every time. But even if we are able to pray at every time, it still may not be possible for us to pray in every place. For example, it is not possible to pray in certain worldly places. Since you cannot pray in those places, you should not go there. If you can pray in a particular place, it is permissible for you to be there. But if you cannot pray in a certain place, you should not be there. According to verse 8, the brothers must bear the unique burden to pray in every place. Pray at work, at home, and in your car. As men, we should be those who pray.

It is significant that Paul opens verse 8 with the words, “I will.” This expression is stronger than “I wish” or “I exhort.” Paul’s use of the word “therefore” indicates, as we pointed out in the previous message, that the elders, the leading ones, are to take the lead in prayer and pave the way for others to follow them to have a prayerful life. In the first message of this Life-study we covered some very important matters related to God’s dispensation. But no matter how important these matters are, they cannot be carried out without the prayer of the brothers. Knowing this, Paul said, “I will therefore that men pray in every place.”

As I am speaking about this matter of praying in every place, I am deeply burdened. I would beg you all, especially the leading ones, from now on to have another kind of life — a life of praying in every place. If you pray in every place, your living will be transformed, and the church in your locality will be transformed also. Some brothers may not be entirely satisfied with the church in their locality. The only way for the church in your locality to be satisfying to you is for you to pray at every time and in every place. Instead of discussing the situation of the church, pray for the church. The normal life of the brothers in the church is to pray in every place.

B. Lifting up holy hands

When we pray in every place, we should lift up holy hands. Hands are a symbol of our doings. Hence, holy hands signify a holy living, a living sanctified and separated unto God. Such a holy life strengthens our prayer life. When our hands are not holy, our living is not separated unto God. We then have no supporting strength to pray, no holy hands to lift up in prayer.

In prayer, we should not lift up our eyes to observe others, but lift up holy hands. If you are watchful over the elders and the saints in a critical way, your prayer life will be killed. But if you lift up holy hands, your prayer will be strengthened.

C. Without wrath and reasoning

In verse 8 Paul also urges the brothers to pray “without wrath and reasoning.” Wrath and reasoning kill our prayer. Wrath is of our emotion, and reasoning is of our mind. To have a prayer life and pray unceasingly, our emotion and mind must be regulated to a normal condition under the control of the Spirit in our spirit.

The Greek word for reasoning means disputatious reasoning. What Paul is speaking of here is not normal or ordinary reasoning, but a reasoning filled with disputation. We must avoid this if we are to pray properly.

Paul’s word about not having disputatious reasonings is related to his admonition to lift up holy hands. If we close our eyes and lift up our hands, we shall be able to pray. But if we open our eyes to consider others and reason about their situation, we shall not be able to pray. Instead of lifting up our hands, we may clasp them behind our back. Who can pray with his hands clasped behind his back? But if we lift up our hands and refrain from disputatious reasoning, we shall be able to pray in a proper way.

From experience I have learned that our prayer life can be affected by our mood. If I do not keep myself in a proper mood, my prayer life is put to death. Anger always destroys our prayer life for a period of time. If a brother loses his temper with his wife, he may find that he cannot pray properly for a few days. If we are to have a prayer life, we must learn not to be moody or angry with others. By the Lord’s grace that is with our spirit, we must exercise a strict control over our emotion.

II. The sisters

In verse 9, Paul turns to the sisters. He begins this verse with the word “similarly.” This refers to “I will” in verse 8. It may also indicate that Paul’s word about praying in every place applies to the sisters as well as to the brothers.

A. Adorning themselves

Verse 9 says, “Similarly, that women adorn themselves in proper clothing with modesty and sobriety, not with braided hair and gold or pearls or costly clothing.” Proper clothing denotes what is fitting to the sisters’ nature and position as saints of God. Clothing in Greek implies deportment, demeanor. Clothing is the main sign of a sister’s demeanor, and it must befit her saintly position.

The Greek word rendered modesty literally is shamefastness, that is, bound or made fast by an honorable shame (Vincent), implying not forward or overbold, but moderate, observing the proprieties of a woman.

Sobriety denotes sober-mindedness, self-restraint. It means to restrict oneself soberly and discreetly. The sisters in a local assembly should clothe themselves with these two virtues — shamefastness and self-restraint — as their demeanor.

In verse 10 Paul continues, “But, what befits women professing godly reverence, by good works.” Godly reverence is reverence toward God; it is the revering and honoring of God as those who worship Him should.

B. Learning

In verse 11 Paul says, “Let a woman learn in quietness in all subjection.” Quietness means silence. For a sister to learn in silence and in all subjection is to realize her position as a woman. This safeguards the sisters from the presumption of overstepping their position in the local assembly.

Verse 12 continues, “But I do not permit a woman to teach or to exercise authority over a man, but to be in quietness.” To teach here means to teach with authority, to define and decide the meaning of doctrines concerning divine truth. For a woman to teach in this way or to exercise authority over a man is to leave her position. In God’s creation man was ordained to be the head, and woman was to be in subjection to man (1 Cor. 11:3). This ordination should be kept in the church. The word quietness in verse 12 refers to silence from speaking.

In verse 13 Paul offers a word of explanation, “For Adam was formed first, then Eve.” This brings us to the beginning. God always wants to bring us back to His beginning (Matt. 19:8).

In verse 14 Paul goes on, “And Adam was not deceived, but the woman being quite deceived was in transgression.” Verse 13 gives the first reason that a woman should subject herself to man. Here is the second. Eve was deceived by the serpent (Gen. 3:1-6) because she did not remain in subjection under the headship of Adam, but overstepped her position to contact the evil tempter directly without her head being covered. This is the strong ground for the apostle not to permit the sisters in a local assembly to teach with authority or to exercise authority over men, but to learn in silence and remain in all subjection. Man’s headship is woman’s protection.

C. Their salvation

In verse 15 Paul concludes, “But she shall be saved through childbearing, if they remain in faith and love and holiness with sobriety.” Childbearing is a suffering. Suffering restricts and protects the fallen one from transgression.

The grammar in verse 15 is rather unusual. At the beginning of the verse Paul says, “She shall be saved”; then he goes on to say, “if they remain in faith and love and holiness with sobriety.” The pronoun “she” refers to Eve in verse 13. The reason Paul changes from a singular to a plural pronoun was that in referring to Eve he was including all women. Not all women are included in the pronoun “she,” but none can deny that they are included in the pronoun “they.” Paul’s use of pronouns in this verse makes it clear that in speaking of Eve he is speaking of all women.

In verse 15 Paul mentions faith, love, and holiness. Faith is to receive the Lord (John 1:12), love is to enjoy Him (John 14:21, 23), and holiness is to express Him through sanctification. By faith we please God (Heb. 11:6), by love we keep the Lord’s word (John 14:23), and by holiness we see Him. (Heb. 12:14).

In this message I am especially burdened concerning modesty, the leading female virtue. In some families there is not adequate stress on modesty. Rather, both boys and girls are brought up and instructed in the same way. Modesty is a virtue which emphasizes the difference between male and female. As we have pointed out, the Greek word rendered “modesty” in 2:9 is literally shamefastness, that is, bound and made fast by an honorable shame.

A word related to the virtue of modesty is shamefacedness. To be shamefaced is to be modest and have a sense of shame and know how to show shame. When a sister speaks in a church meeting, she should do so with modesty, with a certain amount of shamefacedness.

Modesty is a great safeguard and protection to a female. It is a mistake to teach girls in the same way as boys. Boys may expose themselves in certain situations; girls, however, should not. Otherwise, they will be without protection. This lack of protection can open the way for fornication. If the women working in an office have the virtue of modesty, they will be free from any improper involvement with the men who work there. A woman working in an office may easily become involved with a man if she does not have the proper covering, the necessary modesty, shamefacedness, which causes her to keep a proper distance.

All the sisters in the church life should have the virtue of modesty. The sisters should dress according to the principle of modesty. This principle does not allow the exposure of one’s body. For a woman to expose her body is to go against the principle of modesty. A sister needs to have a head covering, not only physically, but also psychologically, ethically, morally, and spiritually. This is the modesty spoken of in the Bible. To be modest simply means that a female is fully covered in every way.

In the church life the brothers and sisters have quite a lot of contact with one another in fellowship. In such fellowship it is necessary for the sisters to wear a moral, ethical, and spiritual covering known as modesty. In all their contact with the brothers, the sisters should be covered with an “overcoat” of modesty. This is a great safeguard and protection.

The sisters should never forget that they are females. This must be true especially of young unmarried sisters. They should be careful not to allow any evil thing to defile their holy body, which has been separated unto God and which is the temple of the Holy Spirit. For a young woman to preserve her body in this way requires modesty. I advise all the young sisters to wear a heavenly cloak to cover themselves from the influence of this evil age. Then they will be preserved for God’s purpose. At the time appointed by God, He will arrange for the right brother to marry a young sister as a virgin. Again and again I would remind the sisters to wear a cloak of modesty. The sisters must always remember that they are females. As females it is necessary for them to be covered. This is modesty.

Along with modesty, the sisters need sobriety (2:9). As a sister is practicing modesty, she needs to be sober. Far from being foolish, she should be sober-minded and discreet. She should be clear about things and have a keen discernment. A sister should be quiet, but she should not be without sobriety and discernment. A sister should be quiet soberly, not foolishly. As a sister exercises herself to be quiet and not to overstep her position, she needs a keen discernment within. Her spiritual sky should be clear, without clouds or smog. Then she will be clear, careful, and discreet.

The two virtues of modesty and sobriety are of great importance in the church life. The sisters should attend the church meetings in order to gain the full knowledge of the truth. This knowledge will cause them to be sober in their understanding. Then, along with their modesty, they will have what Paul calls “holiness with sobriety” (2:15). They will not be holy in a foolish way, in a way devoid of knowledge. On the contrary, they will be holy in a way that is full of knowledge, understanding, and discernment.

In the first two chapters of 1 Timothy Paul gives practical instructions to have a proper local church: (1) terminate the distraction of differing teachings (1:3-11); (2) emphasize God’s dispensation, making it the central line and goal of the Christian life (1:4-6); (3) preach Christ to save sinners (1:12-17); (4) war a good warfare for God’s New Testament economy by holding faith and a good conscience (1:18-19); (5) deal with the heretical teachers and the opposers of the apostle (1:20); (6) let the leading ones take the lead to have a prayer life, interceding for all men that Christ’s redemption may be testified in due time (2:1-7); (7) let the brothers follow the pattern of prayer, praying all the time (2:8); and (8) let the sisters adorn themselves in proper deportment and subject themselves to the brothers, remaining in quietness, faith, love, and holiness with sobriety.

Overseers and Deacons for the Church's Administration

Scripture Reading: 1 Tim. 3:1-13

In 3:1-13 Paul speaks of overseers and deacons for the church's administration. In verses 1 through 7 he covers the overseers, and in verses 8 through 13, the deacons.

I. Overseers

A. Aspiration for oversight

In verse 1 Paul says, "Faithful is the word: If anyone aspires to oversight, he desires a good work." Paul begins with the expression, "Faithful is the word." This expression indicates that what he is about to say is very important.

In verse 1 Paul speaks of oversight, and in verse 2, of overseers. The Greek word rendered oversight is episkope, from epi meaning over and skope meaning sight; hence, oversight, denoting the function of an overseer. The Greek word translated overseer is episkopos from epi and skopos meaning seer; hence, overseer (bishop, from Latin episcopus). An overseer in a local church is an elder (Acts 20:17, 28). The two titles refer to the same person: elder, denoting a person of maturity; and overseer, denoting the function of an elder. It was Ignatius in the second century who taught that an overseer, a bishop, is higher than an elder. From this erroneous teaching came the hierarchy of bishops, archbishops, cardinals, and the pope. This teaching is also the source of the episcopal system of ecclesiastical government. Both the hierarchy and the system are abominable in the eyes of God.

In verse 1 Paul tells us that if anyone aspires to oversight, he desires a good work. Aspiration with a pure motive differs from ambition with an impure motive. It is the Lord's desire that many brothers have the aspiration spoken of here. For the Lord's recovery and for the building up of the local churches, there is the need of the proper leading ones. Hence, aspiration for oversight is not only justifiable, but even admirable. On the one hand, we condemn ambition; on the other hand, we appreciate the fact that many brothers have the aspiration for oversight. A brother with this kind of aspiration truly desires a good work.

B. Qualifications of an overseer

1. Without reproach

In verse 2 Paul says, "The overseer then must be without reproach, husband of one wife, temperate, of a sober mind, orderly, hospitable, apt to teach." Paul first mentions the qualification of being without reproach. This does not denote perfection in the eyes of God, but an irreproachable condition in the eyes of man. An overseer must be one with a good reputation. There should be no ground for others to speak evil of him.

2. Husband of one wife

An overseer should be the husband of one wife. This implies the restraint of the flesh, which is necessary for an elder. It keeps an elder in a simple and pure married life, free from the tangle of a complicated and confused marriage.

3. Temperate

An overseer should be temperate. Temperate here means self-controlled, moderate.

4. Of a sober mind

To be of a sober mind is not only to be sensible, but also to be discreet in understanding. In 1 and 2 Timothy and Titus Paul uses the words sober and sobriety a number of times. All the saints in the church life need to be sober in their understanding. All must have the virtue of sobriety. If we have the Christian virtue of sobriety, we shall be very discerning and full of insight. However, we shall be quiet, not talkative. A talkative person is not a sober person. One who is sober is keen in his understanding, but slow to speak.

In our fellowship as Christians, it is very important that we understand others. Should someone come to you for fellowship, you should not say very much. Instead, listen while the other party does the talking. However, many have the habit of interrupting the other party and speaking too quickly. If we are to have the proper fellowship with others, we need to be inwardly like a calm lake. Talkativeness, however, stirs up the water and causes the lake to become muddy.

The elders should take the lead in all positive aspects of the church life. They should take the lead in prayer and in exhibiting the virtue of sobriety. If a brother is able to be silent for fifteen minutes while someone is having fellowship with him, he is able to meet this qualification to be an elder. When anyone is speaking to him, the elder should be a calm, tranquil lake, clear and transparent. This is one of the qualifications of an overseer. Talkativeness disqualifies a brother from being an elder. A proper elder is one who is quiet, calm, keen in understanding, and very discerning.

5. Orderly

The Greek word rendered orderly in 3:2 also means decorous. To be orderly, decorous, is to have behavior that always fits the situation. It is to be neither too fast nor too slow, neither too bold nor too timid. A decorous person is one who always does what is fitting. One who is decorous talks when talk is necessary and is silent when silence is required. He can also laugh when laughter is appropriate.

This one qualification shows how difficult it is to be an elder. It is not too much to say that being an elder is the most difficult task on earth. How difficult it is to meet even the one qualification of being orderly or decorous! Even in the way he uses the telephone an elder should be decorous. On the one hand, he should not talk too long; on the other hand, if his conversation is too brief, he may offend others. It is possible to go to an extreme even in the matter of the way we use the telephone. One extreme is that a brother takes the telephone off the hook, refusing to talk to anyone. Another extreme is that his telephone conversations are too long. Neither is orderly.

Elders should also be orderly in the way they speak to others. Sometimes they need to speak loudly; at other times, they should speak softly.

Furthermore, they should be orderly in the way they have their hair cut. To have hair that is either too long or too short is not orderly. By these few examples we can see that the requirements of eldership are virtually without limit.

Because the requirements of an elder are so many and so difficult, it is surely vain for anyone to be ambitious for eldership. Those who have this ambition simply do not know how difficult it is to be an elder. If a brother does not have a genuine aspiration with a pure motive for the Lord's recovery, he should not desire to be an elder. He should seek to fulfill his ambition outside the church, not in pursuing the eldership. The church is not an arena for a brother to satisfy his ambition.

The eldership is very demanding, and the requirements are extremely high. For this reason, I sympathize with the elders. From experience I know that they will receive telephone calls even in the middle of the night. They have no choice but to answer the telephone and take care of the situation of the one who calls.

At this point I would like to speak a word of comfort and encouragement to those who are children of elders. An elder's children may be troubled by the fact that their father gives so much of his time to the church. If an elder fails to give adequate time to the church life, he cannot fulfill his responsibility properly. However, because the church takes so much of his time, he has relatively little time to devote to his children. I would encourage the children of elders to realize that for their father to give his time to the church is very acceptable to God. Temporarily the children may have some hardship. But the Lord will reward them. Instead of being disappointed by their situation, they should be glad that their father has consecrated his life and time to the Lord's recovery. Eventually, the children of an elder will enjoy the Lord's reward.

To be an elder is a great blessing to one's family and to the church. It is surely worthwhile for a brother to aspire to oversight. Although being an elder is a most difficult job, it is a great blessing.

Those who are elders in the churches in the Lord's recovery are burdened by the Lord and chosen according to the insight, oversight, and foresight of the spiritual eyes of the church. They are not elected, and they are very different from those who may be called elders in different denominations.

6. Hospitable

Another qualification of an overseer is that he must be hospitable. Hospitality requires love, care for people, and endurance. All these virtues are required if one is to qualify to be an elder.

Nothing is more bothersome than giving hospitality. Hospitality tests the qualifications of elders. The principle of hospitality is giving without receiving; it is suffering without requiring anything in return. Hospitality means sacrifice with joy, but without recompense. An elder must have a heart and a spirit for such hospitality.

7. Apt to teach

In verse 2 Paul says that an elder should be apt to teach. To teach here is similar to parents teaching their children. An elder must be apt to render this kind of home teaching to the members of the local church.

If a parent has not received a proper education, it will be difficult for him to teach his children. Likewise, if the elders would be apt to teach, they need to be knowledgeable. For example, an elder should be able to explain what the mystery of Christ is. If a brother is not knowledgeable concerning the truth, he is disqualified from the eldership. An elder should be able to teach the saints like a parent helps a child with his homework. However, this does not mean that every elder should be a teacher. It is not necessary for parents to be teachers in order to help their children with homework. Similarly, not all elders are teachers, but they all should be apt to teach.

8. Not an excessive drinker

In verse 3 Paul lists other qualifications: "Not an excessive drinker, not a striker, but forbearing, not contentious, not fond of money." When Paul says that an elder should not be an excessive drinker, he, of course, has in mind not an excessive drinker of wine. However, the principle here is that an elder should not be excessive in anything. This requires strong self-control. In the matters of food and clothing, for example, an elder should not be excessive. This tests his ability to exercise self-control.

9. Not a striker

The next requirement, "not a striker," is related to the control of one's temper. This implies a strong restraint of the temper. An elder should be one who does not lose his temper.

10. Forbearing

To be forbearing is to be yielding, gentle, mild, reasonable, and considerate in dealing with others. It is to deal with people without strictness.

11. Not contentious

An elder should not be contentious. He should not be quarrelsome; rather, he should be peaceable and not debate with others or contend with them. Even if someone comes to fight with him, he should not fight back, but should learn not to be contentious.

12. Not fond of money

An elder should not be fond of money. Money is a test to all men. An elder must be pure in money matters, especially since the church fund is under the elders' management (Acts 11:30). An elder must realize that the money which passes through his hands is not for his personal gain. He should not have even the thought of monetary gain.

13. Managing well his own household

In verses 4 and 5 Paul goes on to say, "One who manages well his own household, having his children in subjection with all gravity; (but if anyone does not know how to manage his own household, how will he take care of the church of God?)" Managing well his own household is a proof that one is qualified to take the oversight of a local church. An elder should exercise to manage his household well and maintain it in good order. It is clear that anyone who does not know how to manage his own household cannot take care of the church of God.

14. Not a new convert

Verse 6 says, "Not a new convert, lest being blinded with pride he fall into the judgment of the Devil." The Greek word rendered blinded literally means beclouded with smoke. Pride here is likened to smoke that beclouds the mind, making it blind, besotted with the self-conceit of pride. One who is blinded with pride may fall into the judgment of the Devil. This judgment refers to that to which Satan was sentenced due to his pride in his high position (Ezek. 28:13-17). The Devil was judged because of his rebellion which came from pride. The Devil was proud, blind, and rebellious. For this, he received God's judgment.

15. Having a good testimony from those outside

In verse 7 Paul concludes, "And he also must have a good testimony from those outside, that he may not fall into reproach and the snare of the Devil." An elder must be right with himself, with his family, with the church, and with those outside — the society. And, according to the context, an elder must be right in intention, in motive, in character, in attitude, in words, and in deeds.

To fall into the judgment of the Devil is due to the pride of the elder himself; to fall into the snare of the Devil is occasioned by the reproach of outsiders. An elder should be alert not to be proud on the one hand, and not to be reproachable on the other, that he may avoid the Devil's entanglement.

II. Deacons

A. Qualifications of a deacon

In verse 8 Paul says, "Deacons must similarly be grave, not double-tongued, not addicted to much wine, not seeking gain by base means." Deacons are serving ones. The overseers take care of the church; the deacons serve the church under the direction of the elders. These are the only two offices in a local church.

1. Grave

Deacons are to be grave. This virtue inspires and invites honor and respect. A person who is grave is neither loose nor light.

2. Not double-tongued

A serpent is double-tongued. A deacon in a local church rendering service to all the saints may easily be double-tongued in contacting them. In that case, he practices the nature of the Devil and brings death into the church life.

Today we often use the expression two-faced instead of double-tongued. A two-faced person is hypocritical. He may speak one way to a brother in his presence and another way about the brother in his absence. Deacons should be neither double-tongued nor two-faced. If you do not have the Lord's leading to speak frankly to a brother about his situation, simply be quiet. Do not say anything to please him. Furthermore, you should not speak negatively about him behind his back.

The deacons should fulfill their duty without talking too much. However, there is a great temptation to talk excessively. In their contact with the elders, the deacons may acquire information about certain matters. It is tempting to pass on this information. When a deacon behaves in this way, he becomes the information center of the church. The deacons should not be informers. Restricting the circulation of needless information will kill the germs of death in the church life.

3. Not addicted to much wine

Deacons should not be addicted to much wine. Being addicted to much wine is a sign of being unable to control oneself. A deacon in the service of a local church must exercise self-control in a full way.

4. Not seeking gain by base means

A deacon also should not seek gain by base means. He should not seek gain from rendering service to the saints. This is seeking gain by base means (see 6:5b). A deacon, therefore, should not be fond of money.

5. Holding the mystery of the faith in a pure conscience

Verse 9 says, "Holding the mystery of the faith in a pure conscience." The faith here, as in 1:19 and 2 Timothy 4:7, is objective. It refers to the things we believe in, the things which constitute the gospel. The mystery of the faith is mainly Christ as the mystery of God (Col. 2:2) and the church as the mystery of Christ (Eph. 3:4). A deacon in a local church should hold this mystery with full understanding in a pure conscience for the Lord's testimony.

If the deacons know the mystery of the faith, the standard of their service will be uplifted. Whenever the deacons are asked by the elders to do a certain thing or to help others in a particular way, they should realize that they are serving the saints in the mystery of the faith. This will uplift their service. It makes a tremendous difference if the deacons' contact with others is based on God's New Testament economy.

Years ago, I visited the royal palace in London. I noticed that every aspect of the service of the palace, from the changing of the guard to the work of the janitors, was done with a high standard and with dignity. Even the janitors conducted themselves with dignity and gravity, in a way which invited others' respect. How much more true this should be of the service of the deacons in a local church! Even the cleaning of the rest rooms should be done with gravity. Those who serve in this way should realize that they are not cleaning in a worldly place. Rather, they are serving the church, the house of God.

In verse 9 Paul speaks of a pure conscience. A pure conscience is a conscience purified from any mixture. To hold the mystery of the faith for the Lord's testimony, we need such a purified conscience.

In order to have a pure conscience, the deacons need to behave according to their knowledge of the mystery of the faith. We may know this mystery, but not live according to it. As a result, instead of having a pure conscience, we have a conscience that condemns us. A deacon should consider how he deals with his wife, his children, and the other saints. He then may realize his shortage, that he does not live according to the mystery of the faith. A deacon must be justified in the first place by his own conscience. He should have a conscience which testifies even to the demons that he lives according to the standard of the mystery of God's New Testament economy. Then he will truly hold the mystery of the faith with a pure conscience.

6. Unreprovable

In verse 10 Paul continues, "And let these also first be proved; then let them minister, being Unreprovable." Unreprovable here means blameless. The word that the deacons should first be proved may imply a period of apprenticeship. The word minister in this verse means to serve. This is the function of a deacon.

7. Husband of one wife

Verse 12 says, "Let deacons be husbands of one wife." The requirement here is the same as that of the overseers, as mentioned in verse 2.

8. Managing his children and his own household well

In verse 12 Paul also says that deacons should manage "their children and their own households well." Managing the children and the household well proves the capability of a brother to serve the church.

B. Blessing on a good deacon

1. Obtaining a good standing

In verse 13 Paul mentions the blessing on a good deacon: "For those who have ministered well obtain for themselves a good standing and much boldness in faith which is in Christ Jesus." The word ministered here means served. The expression "a good standing" refers to a firm and steadfast standing as a believer and a saint before God and man. To serve the church well as a deacon strengthens one's Christian standing.

2. Obtaining much boldness in faith which is in Christ Jesus

By serving well, a deacon will also be blessed with much boldness in faith which is in Christ Jesus. The word boldness also means confidence. To serve the church well strengthens the boldness, the confidence, of the Christian faith. Faith here is subjective and refers to our act of believing.

III. Deaconesses

Verse 11 says, "Women similarly must be grave, not slanderers, temperate, faithful in all things." The word women in this verse refers to deaconesses (Rom. 16:1), not to the wives of the deacons. Sisters who are serving ones in the church are deaconesses. Such ones must be grave. Furthermore, they should not be slanderers. This corresponds to "not double-tongued" in verse 8. The Devil is a slanderer (Rev. 12:10). To slander is to practice the nature of the evil slanderer. A sister who is a deaconess, a serving one in a local church among many other sisters, should flee slander, the evil act of the Devil.

Deaconesses must also be temperate and faithful in all things. We have pointed out that to be temperate is to be self-controlled, moderate. The charge to be "faithful in all things" corresponds to "not seeking gain by base means" in verse 8. A sister as a deaconess needs to be faithful, trustworthy in all things, especially in things concerning gain.

The Function of the Church

Scripture Reading: 1 Tim. 3:14-16

First Timothy 3:14-16 is the most crucial portion in the four books of 1 and 2 Timothy, Titus, and Philemon. Paul has covered the matters of the differing teachings, the dispensation of God, the need for the leading ones to have a prayer life so that all the other brothers may follow, and the charge to the sisters to remain in faith, love, and holiness with sobriety. Furthermore, the elders have been established and the deacons have been appointed. A church that has all these characteristics is certainly wonderful. Now in verse 15 Paul tells us that the church is the house of the living God, the pillar and base of the truth. Then in verse 16 he goes on to declare: “And confessedly, great is the mystery of godliness, Who was manifested in the flesh, vindicated in the Spirit, seen by angels, preached among the nations, believed on in the world, taken up in glory.” In these verses Paul presents an extremely high standard for the church.

Among Christians today the standard of the church is far below God’s standard revealed in 3:15 and 16. In order to reach this standard, the church must have all the characteristics described in the first two and a half chapters of 1 Timothy. There must be no differing teachings, and God’s economy must be practiced continually. The leading ones must have a prayer life, and all the other brothers must follow them to pray in every place. Furthermore, the sisters should remain in faith, love, and holiness with sobriety. Then the government of the church must be established with the two offices of elders and deacons. It is our expectation to practice this kind of church life. We praise the Lord that in His recovery we have seen such a church life at least to a certain extent. Whenever God’s standard for the church is attained as outlined in 1 Timothy, the church will function as the house of the living God and the pillar and base upholding the truth. This is also the great mystery of godliness, the manifestation of God in the flesh. Not only was the Lord Jesus the manifestation of God in the past; the church today should also be the manifestation of God. This is the goal, the aim, of these four Epistles written by Paul.

Even though Paul witnessed the beginning of the decline of the church, he was not disappointed or discouraged. Because he had both insight and foresight, he could be encouraged. He knew that some day and somehow the church would reach God’s standard. The majority of the believers may decline, but a small number at least would be chosen, preserved, and established to practice the church life according to the divine standard.

We in the Lord’s recovery can testify of the great difference between the recovery and today’s organized Christianity. Reconciliation between the two is impossible. All the saints should be encouraged that the situation in the Lord’s recovery is heading toward God’s standard. This standard is that the church should function as the house of the living God, the pillar and base of the truth, and as the great mystery of godliness, God manifest in the flesh. The church life today must be the manifestation of God in the flesh. When visitors, including those who have not yet believed in the Lord, come to the meetings and behold such a manifestation, they will no doubt be greatly surprised. They may say, “What is this? It is different from anything we have seen elsewhere. It is even different from the church services in religion.” Yes, the church is different; it is the house of the living God, the pillar and base of the truth, and the manifestation of God in the flesh. Every local church must reach this standard and continue according to it. There should be no decline; rather, we should maintain God’s standard until the glorious appearing of our Head, the Savior, Jesus Christ.

In 3:14 Paul says, “These things I write to you, hoping to come to you shortly.” By “these things” Paul means all he has covered thus far in this Epistle. When he wrote this book, he was hoping to come shortly to see Timothy.

I. The house of the living God

Verse 15 continues, “But if I delay, that you may know how one ought to conduct himself in the house of God, which is the church of the living God, the pillar and base of the truth.” The words “know how one ought to conduct himself” indicate that in this book Paul gives instructions concerning how to take care of a local church.

According to Paul’s word in verse 15, the church is the house of God. The Greek word rendered house may also be translated household. The same word is used in 3:4, 5, and 12. The household, the family, of God is the house of God. The house and the household are one thing — the assembly of the believers (Eph. 2:19; Heb. 3:6). The reality of this house as the dwelling place of the living God is in our spirit (Eph. 2:22). We must live and act in our spirit so that God can be manifested in this house as the living God.

As God’s dwelling place, the church is both God’s house and His household, His family. In the Old Testament, the temple and God’s people, His family, were two separate things. But in the fulfillment in the New Testament, the dwelling place and the family are one. The family is God’s dwelling place, and God’s dwelling place is His family. As we have indicated, the Greek word for house may be translated either as house or household. According to God’s New Testament economy, God’s family is His house. These are not two separate things; they are actually one. We are God’s family and also His temple, His dwelling place.

In speaking of the church as the house of God, Paul specifically refers to God as the living God. The living God who lives in the church must be subjective to the church rather than merely objective. An idol in a heathen temple is lifeless. The God who not only lives but also acts, moves, and works in His living temple, the church, is living. Because He is living, the church is also living in Him, by Him, and with Him. A living God and a living church live, move, and work together. The living church is the house and the household of the living God. Hence, it becomes the manifestation of God in the flesh.

II. The pillar and base of the truth

Speaking metaphorically, Paul goes on to say that the church is “the pillar and base of the truth.” The pillar supports the building, and the base holds the pillar. The church is such a supporting pillar and holding base of the truth.

The truth here refers to the real things which are revealed in the New Testament concerning Christ and the church according to God’s New Testament economy. The church is the supporting pillar and holding base of all these realities. A local church should be such a building that holds, bears, and testifies the truth, the reality, of Christ and the church.

The church as the house of the living God is both the pillar which bears the truth and the base which upholds the pillar. As we have pointed out, the truth is the reality and the contents of God’s New Testament economy. This economy is composed of two mysteries: Christ as the mystery of God (Col. 2:2) and the church as the mystery of Christ (Eph. 3:4). Christ and the church, the Head and the Body, are the contents of the reality of God’s New Testament economy.

III. The mystery of godliness

Verse 16 begins with the words, “And confessedly, great is the mystery of godliness.” The conjunction “and” in verse 16 indicates that Paul has not finished speaking about the church in verse 15. Oh, the church is a great matter! It is the house of the living God and the pillar and base of the truth. Paul’s use of the conjunction at the beginning of verse 16 indicates that the church is something even more than the house of the living God and the pillar and base of the truth. The church is also the mystery of godliness. The church is the house, the pillar and the base, and the mystery of godliness.

According to the context, godliness in verse 16 refers not only to piety, but to the living of God in the church, that is, God as life lived out in the church. This is the great mystery confessed universally by believers in Christ.

The church as the house of the living God and as the pillar and base of the truth is not so mysterious. But the church as the manifestation of God in the flesh certainly is a mystery. A mystery always goes beyond our understanding. It refers to something which cannot be explained. If we are able to explain a certain matter, it is not a mystery.

The church is not only the house of the living God and the pillar and base of the truth, but also the mystery of godliness. Godliness refers to God expressed. What are we doing in the church life? We are expressing God. Human beings may not realize this adequately, but the angels recognize it and appreciate it. On the one hand, the good angels rejoice when they behold the expression of God in the church. On the other hand, the evil angels and the demons tremble in fear. They realize that eventually those in the church life will condemn them to the lake of fire.

When the Lord Jesus was born, a host of angels praised God (Luke 2:10-14). If the angels rejoiced at the birth of the Lord Jesus in Bethlehem, the city of David, will they not also rejoice to see God manifested in the church, which is Christ's increase and enlargement? Furthermore, when the Lord Jesus, living out God and manifesting Him on earth, confronted the demons, the demons cried out. In at least one case they begged the Lord Jesus not to send them into the abyss (Luke 8:31). If the demons trembled at the presence of the Lord Jesus, will they not also tremble at the manifestation of the living God in the church? No doubt when the church is living out God and manifesting Him, the demons and the evil angels will be terrified. Every local church must be a place where Christ is born anew in the saints. Furthermore, every local church must live out God in such a way that the Devil's time is shortened. On the one hand, when the churches come up to God's standard, the angels will sing and rejoice; on the other hand, the demons and the evil angels will tremble.

It may come as a surprise that in verse 16 Paul suddenly uses the relative pronoun "who," when he says, "Who was manifested in the flesh." In Greek the antecedent of this relative pronoun is omitted, but easily recognized, that is, Christ who was God manifested in the flesh as the mystery of godliness. The transition from "the mystery..." to "Who" implies that Christ as the manifestation of God in the flesh is the mystery of godliness (Col. 1:27; Gal. 2:20). This mystery of godliness is the living of a proper church, and such a living is also the manifestation of God in the flesh. The portion of verse 16 from "Who was manifested" to "taken up in glory" may have been a church song in the early days.

The first part of verse 16 speaks of a matter — the mystery of godliness. Hence, we would expect Paul to use the relative pronoun "which" to refer to the mystery of godliness as a matter. However, the fact that he uses the relative pronoun "Who" implies that the mystery of godliness is a person and not merely a matter. As we shall see, this person is Christ as the Head with His Body.

Through incarnation and human living (John 1:1, 14), God was manifested in the flesh. "In the flesh" means in the likeness, in the fashion, of man (Rom. 8:3; Phil. 2:7-8). In the form of man Christ appeared to people (2 Cor. 5:16), yet He was God manifested in a man.

Christ was also "vindicated in the Spirit." The Greek word also means justified. The incarnated Christ in His human living was not only vindicated as the Son of God by the Spirit (Matt. 3:16-17; Rom. 1:3-4), but was also justified, proved, and approved as right and righteous by the Spirit (Matt. 3:15-16; 4:1). He was manifested in the flesh, but vindicated and justified in the Spirit. He appeared in the flesh, but He lived in the Spirit (Luke 4:1, 14; Matt. 12:28) and offered Himself to God through the Spirit (Heb. 9:14). His transfiguration (Matt. 17:2) and His resurrection are all vindications of the Spirit. Furthermore, in resurrection He even became the life-giving Spirit (1 Cor. 15:45; 2 Cor. 3:17) to dwell and live in us (Rom. 8:9-10) for the manifestation of God in the flesh as the mystery of godliness. Hence, now we know Him and His members no longer according to the flesh, but according to the Spirit (2 Cor. 5:16). Since the manifestation of God in the flesh is vindicated in the Spirit, and the Spirit is one with our spirit (Rom. 8:16), we must live and behave in our spirit that this vindication may be accomplished.

Paul also says "seen by angels." Angels saw the incarnation, human living, and ascension of Christ (Luke 2:9-14; Matt. 4:11; Acts 1:10-11; Rev. 5:6, 11-12).

Christ was also preached among the nations. Christ as God's manifestation in the flesh has been preached as the gospel among the nations, including the nation of Israel, from the day of Pentecost (Rom. 16:26; Eph. 3:8).

Furthermore, Christ has been "believed on in the world." Christ as the embodiment of God in the flesh has been believed on, received as Savior and life, by people in the world (Acts 13:48).

Paul concludes verse 16 with the phrase "taken up in glory." This refers to Christ's ascension into glory (Mark 16:19; Acts 1:9-11; 2:33; Phil. 2:9). According to the sequence of historical events, Christ's ascension preceded His being preached among the nations. However, it is listed here as the last event of Christ being the manifestation of God in the flesh. This seems to indicate the church taken up in glory. Hence, it implies that not only Christ Himself as the Head, but also the church as the Body, is the manifestation of God in the flesh. When a church is well taken care of according to the instructions given in the first two chapters, with the oversight of the elders and the service of the deacons fully established, as revealed in chapter three, the church will function as the house and household of the living God for His move on the earth and as the supporting pillar and holding base of the truth, bearing the divine reality of Christ and His Body as a testimony to the world. Then the church becomes the continuation of Christ's manifestation of God in the flesh. This is the great mystery of godliness — Christ lived out of the church as the manifestation of God in the flesh!

I wish to emphasize the fact that although Christ was taken up in glory (Acts 1) before the preaching of Him began in Acts 2, Paul mentions this last, not only after the preaching, but even after being believed on in the world. This indicates that "taken up in glory" may include not only the ascension of Christ, but also the rapture of the church. The Head, Christ, was taken up before the preaching of Him began; however, the Body, the church, will be taken up only after Christ has been preached and believed on in the world. Therefore, in verse 16 there is a definite indication that this verse refers not only to the Head as the manifestation of God in the flesh, but also to the Body as the continuation of this manifestation. This is indeed logical, for how can a person's head function in isolation from his body? The Head, Christ, has been taken up in glory, and the Body, the church, will also be taken up in glory. Both the Head and the Body are the mystery of godliness. This is the manifestation of God in the flesh.

The Prediction of the Decline of the Church

Scripture Reading: 1 Tim. 4:1-5

In this message we shall consider the prediction of the decline of the church as presented in 4:1-5.

I. The spirit's prediction

In 4:1 Paul says, "But the Spirit says expressly that in later times some will depart from the faith, giving heed to deceiving spirits and teachings of demons." The fact that this verse begins with the word "but" indicates that what follows is in contrast to what is mentioned in 3:15 and 16. At the end of chapter three, Paul reached the high point of the four Epistles of 1 and 2 Timothy, Titus, and Philemon, presenting a glorious picture of the church. However, in 4:1-5, he describes something very dark, something much in contrast to the situation in 3:15 and 16.

In 4:1 Paul uses the expression "the Spirit says expressly." This is the Spirit who dwells in our spirit and speaks to us there (Rom. 8:9-11, 16). We need to exercise our spirit that it may become keen and clear to listen to the Spirit's speaking and be kept from the deceiving spirits and teachings of demons.

Many in today's Pentecostal movement follow the Old Testament way of prophesying and say, "Thus saith the Lord." This expression cannot be found in the New Testament. In the New Testament we see the principle of incarnation. According to this principle, God does not speak directly. Rather, He speaks through man. First, in Jesus Christ God became incarnated and mingled with man. Now after the death and resurrection of Christ, it is possible for Him to be one spirit with those who believe in Christ. In 1 Corinthians 6:17 Paul declares, "He that is joined unto the Lord is one spirit." This refers to the mingled spirit, the divine Spirit mingled with the regenerated human spirit. In the New Testament it is this mingled spirit which does the speaking. For this reason, 4:1 does not say, "The Spirit of God says," nor, "The Holy Spirit says." Instead, this verse reads, "The Spirit says..." According to the principle of incarnation revealed in the New Testament, this implies our spirit. We have seen that the principle of incarnation means that divinity is brought into humanity and works with humanity. Hence, when the Spirit speaks, He speaks within our spirit, through our spirit, and out from our spirit. If there were no one who was truly one spirit with the speaking God, there would be no way, according to the New Testament principle, for God to speak.

Paul took the lead to be one spirit with the Lord. Because he was one with Him in this way, Paul was able to speak a great deal for the Lord. In 1 Corinthians 7 Paul says definitely that concerning a particular matter he does not have a word from the Lord, but that he gives his opinion, his judgment, as one who has received the mercy of the Lord to be faithful (v. 25). But as we read this portion of the Bible today, we see that Paul's word is in fact the word of the Lord. When Paul spoke, the Triune God, who has been processed to become the Spirit and who was mingled with Paul's regenerated spirit, spoke from within him. We also have such a mingled spirit within us today. It is in and through this mingled spirit that the Spirit speaks expressly.

First Timothy 4:1 is a continuation of 3:15 and 16. No doubt, these latter verses were Paul's words. Now in 4:1 Paul says that the Spirit speaks expressly. Where was the Spirit speaking? There can be no doubt that the Spirit was speaking from within Paul. As Paul was writing to Timothy about the church as the house of God, the pillar and base of the truth, and the great mystery of godliness, the Spirit was speaking in his spirit. This is not the Spirit who suddenly descends upon us and causes us to prophesy, "Thus saith the Lord." The speaking of the Spirit in 4:1 is according to the way of incarnation. The Spirit spoke from within Paul's spirit.

If we would hear the speaking of the Spirit, we need to exercise our spirit. Only our spirit can listen to the speaking of the Spirit. The mind is not qualified for this; it lacks the ability to listen to the Spirit's speaking. The Spirit speaks to our spirit, and our spirit responds to the Spirit. Therefore, as we read 1 Timothy, we must exercise our spirit to listen to the Spirit speaking from within the spirit of the Apostle Paul.

II. Departing from the faith

According to 4:1, the Spirit says that in later times some will depart from the faith. The later times, or after times, refer to times after the writing of this book. This differs from the last days in 2 Timothy 3:1, which denote the closing period of this age.

As he was writing this Epistle, Paul realized that in time to come some would depart from the faith. In this verse the faith is objective and refers to the contents of our belief. On the one hand, Paul was bold and encouraged, not in the least disappointed. He believed that the church was the house of the living God, the pillar and base of the truth, and even the mystery of godliness. On the other hand, deep within his spirit, he knew that certain so-called believers would depart from the faith, from God's New Testament economy. Paul could know this because the Spirit who was mingled with his spirit revealed it to him. This departure from God's New Testament economy would be the beginning of the decline of the church life.

Paul says that those who depart from the faith will give heed to deceiving spirits and teachings of demons. Many Christians do not realize that, according to the Bible, there are two categories of evil spirits. The deceiving spirits in 4:1 are in contrast to the Spirit, as mentioned in 1 John 4:1, 3, and 6. These are the fallen angels who followed Satan in his rebellion and became his subordinates, who work for his kingdom of darkness (Matt. 25:41; Eph. 6:12). Demons are the unclean and evil spirits (Matt. 12:22, 43; Luke 8:2) of the living creatures on earth in the pre-adamic age who joined Satan's rebellion and were judged by God (see Life-study of Genesis, Message Two). After being judged, they became demons, working on earth for Satan's kingdom. The demons differ from the deceiving spirits, the fallen angels. The fallen angels are in the air, whereas the demons are active on earth.

In verse 1 Paul speaks of both the deceiving spirits in the air and the demons on earth. Among Christians today there are deceptive doctrines which come from the deceiving spirits in the air and also teachings which originate with demons. The history of the church has proved that Paul was right in saying that such teachings and doctrines would come in and that those who depart from the faith would give heed to them.

In verse 2 Paul continues, "In the hypocrisy of men who speak lies, seared in their own conscience as with a branding iron." The phrase "in the hypocrisy of men who speak lies" modifies teachings of demons in verse 1. The teachings of demons are carried out in the hypocrisy of those who lie. This indicates that demons and lying speakers collaborate to deceive people. These hypocrites work together with evil spirits and demons to bring in deceitful teachings and demonic doctrines.

The conscience of hypocritical liars has lost its sense as if seared with a hot branding iron, an iron used to brand the slaves and cattle of a certain owner. This book strongly stresses the conscience. In the church life the love which is contrary to envy and discord is of a good conscience (1:5). Those who thrust away a good conscience become shipwrecked regarding the faith (1:19). The serving ones in the church must hold the mystery of the faith in a pure conscience (3:9). To keep a good and pure conscience is to keep the conscience sensitive in its function. This will safeguard us from the demonic and hypocritical teachings of deceiving liars.

When I was young, I had confidence in anyone who testified that he was a Christian. One day, Brother Nee pointed out the fact that some Christians lie. I wondered how a Christian could be a liar. The Bible says that Satan is the father of lies (John 8:44). Eventually I learned from experience that Christians can lie. In the case of these lying Christians, it seems as if their conscience has been seared and has lost its function. Today many lies have been spread about us by Christians. Some have even gone so far as to put these lies into print. But our conscience testifies that we in the Lord's recovery surely believe the truth revealed in the Bible, perhaps more than other Christians.

We in the Lord's recovery should not only know God's dispensation, but should also know Satan's evil plot. We must see the sharp contrast between the situation at the end of chapter three and that described at the beginning of chapter four. We need to be discerning, sober-minded, and clear concerning the difference between today's Christianity and the Lord's recovery. We must also know what the Devil is doing through evil spirits, demons, and those who speak lies in hypocrisy.

Verse 3 says, "Forbidding to marry, commanding to abstain from foods which God has created to be partaken of with thanksgiving by those who believe and have fully known the truth." Marriage and eating were ordained by God. Eating is for the existence of mankind, and marriage for the continuation and multiplication of mankind. Satan, on the one hand, causes men to abuse these two things in the indulgence of their lustful flesh; on the other hand, he causes men to be unbalanced in the way of asceticism by forbidding marriage and the eating of certain foods. This is a demonic teaching!

Marriage was ordained by God for the carrying out of God's purpose with man. Food is necessary to sustain mankind to exist on earth for the fulfillment of God's purpose. But Satan, through the deceiving spirits and the teachings of demons with the collaboration of hypocrites and liars, seeks to destroy these things, either causing people to abuse them through indulgence or to practice asceticism.

III. The truth concerning food

In verse 3 Paul speaks of "foods which God has created to be partaken of with thanksgiving." All edible things were created by God for men to live on. We should partake of them with thanksgiving to God out of a grateful heart.

Because all food is God's gift to us, we should receive it with thanksgiving. As we partake of our food, we should say, "Lord, thank You." However, we do not have to follow the traditional ritual of saying a so-called word of grace. On the one hand, I do not agree with the practice of such a ritual; on the other hand, I do not agree with neglecting to thank the Lord for the food He has given us. I can testify that I thank the Lord again and again for my food. I even thank Him for a glass of water and say, "Lord, this water is a gift from You, and I thank You for it." Those who practice saying "grace" usually do so before they start eating. But we should thank the Lord for our food not only before we eat it, but also while we are partaking of it and when we have finished our meal. Furthermore, we may express our thanks for each particular item we eat.

The foods God has created should be partaken of with thanksgiving "by those who believe and have fully known the truth." To believe is to be saved and thus begin in the spiritual life. To have fully known the truth is to realize God's purpose in His economy and to grow unto maturity in the spiritual life. God desires all men to be saved and to come to the full knowledge of the truth (2:4). The truth here is God's New Testament economy. As those who are saved by believing in the Lord Jesus for salvation and who know the content, the reality, of God's economy concerning Christ as the mystery of God and the church as the mystery of Christ, we should be thankful for all the food we eat. Those who believe and who know the truth are qualified to receive their food with thanksgiving. We know that we are living on earth for God and for His purpose. Thus, we receive what He has prepared for our sustenance, and we thank Him for it all.

In verses 4 and 5 Paul goes on to say, "For every creature of God is good, and nothing is to be rejected, being received with thanksgiving; for it is sanctified through the word of God and intercession." The statement that "every creature of God is good" is contrary both to Gnosticism, which teaches that some created things are evil, and to ascetic teachings that command men to abstain from certain foods. Some insist that we should eat only vegetables and not meat. But according to Paul's word, every creature of God is good.

Furthermore, Paul says that "nothing is to be rejected." In the past, I politely said, "No, thank you," when I was served certain foods at Cantonese feasts. In particular, I declined to eat turtle, snake, or frogs. I simply was unable to eat those things. But according to Paul's word, we should not reject anything created by Him, but receive all things with thanksgiving.

In verse 5 Paul concludes, "For it is sanctified through the word of God and intercession." All the food we eat can be sanctified, separated unto God for His purpose, through the word of God and intercession. Here the word of God refers to the word of our prayer addressed to God, of which part may be quotations from the Scriptures, or part, messages we hear and read. In this verse intercession refers to our prayer to God for the food we eat. Such prayer separates our food from being common and sanctifies it unto God for His purpose, that is, to nourish us that we may live for Him.

Many versions do not have the boldness to use the word intercession, even though this is the meaning of the Greek word. Instead, they render the Greek word as prayer. But here Paul is definitely saying that we should make intercession for our food. We may pray for ourselves, but we intercede either for someone else or for something. According to Paul's word in this verse, we need to intercede for our food and ask the Lord to sanctify it. Whenever we sit down to eat, we should pray for the food and make intercession for it, saying, "Lord, sanctify this food for Your purpose that it may nourish Your servant. Lord, I believe, and I know the truth. I am here on earth for You and for Your economy. I need this food, and I ask that it be sanctified, separated, to Yourself for the fulfillment of Your economy." In the eyes of God, after intercession has been made for our food in this way, the food becomes holy. This is the proper way to receive our God-given food with thanksgiving.

A Good Minister of Christ

Scripture Reading: 1 Tim. 4:6-16

In 4:6 Paul uses the expression “a good minister of Christ Jesus.” A minister of Christ is one who serves others with Christ, ministering Christ as Savior, life, life supply, and every positive thing. He differs from a teacher of the law and of other things (3, 1 Tim. 1:7).

I. Laying these things before the brothers

A minister of Christ does not mainly denote a minister who belongs to Christ, but a person who ministers Christ to others. He is one who serves people with Christ. For example, if we say that a man is a serving one of a particular meal, we do not mean, of course, that he belongs to the meal. We mean that he serves others with that meal. In like manner, although it is true that a minister of Christ belongs to Christ, the main thought here is that he serves others with Christ, ministering Christ to them. Not only does he belong to Christ, but he serves Christ to others.

In today’s Christianity there are a great many ministers who belong to Christ, but very few of them minister Christ to others. To be a minister of Christ does not primarily mean to preach Christ, teach Christ, or tell others about Christ. The main significance of this term is ministering Christ to others.

Verse 6 confirms this understanding of the expression “a good minister of Christ.” Here Paul says, “Laying these things before the brothers, you will be a good minister of Christ Jesus, being nourished with the words of the faith and of the good teaching which you have closely followed.” By “these things” Paul means all he has covered thus far in this Epistle. Just as a steward lays different courses of food before guests at a dinner, so a good minister of Christ should lay “these things” before the believers. Furthermore, Paul’s use of the term “being nourished” indicates that his concept is that of supplying life to others. It is significant that here Paul does not say “being taught,” but “being nourished” with the words of the faith. If we would minister Christ to others, we ourselves must first be nourished. Being nourished with Christ, we shall have Christ as food, as life supply, to minister to others. The words “being nourished” give us the ground to say that a good minister of Christ does not merely teach others about Christ, but ministers Christ into others as food. Others should be able to testify of us that we have nourished them with Christ.

Throughout the years, my aim in the ministry has been to nourish the saints. No doubt I have passed on a good deal of knowledge. But I can testify that in every message, I exercise my spirit not just to pass on knowledge, but, while I am giving forth a certain kind of knowledge, to supply something nourishing to the Lord’s people. My desire is to minister the riches of Christ as food that the saints may be nourished. Recently, many have written me letters telling how they have been richly fed with Christ through the messages.

If you have a heart to care for others in the Lord’s recovery, you should not give them mere teaching. Whenever you fellowship with others concerning Christ, you may give them some knowledge. But while you are teaching them, you need to exercise your spirit to minister spiritual food that they may be nourished. If you do this, you will be a good minister of Christ.

With Paul and Timothy we see an excellent pattern. As we have pointed out, Paul told Timothy to lay “these things before the brothers,” referring to the things which he was writing in this Epistle. However, before Timothy could lay these things before others, he first had to feed on them himself. He had to digest them, assimilate them, and allow them to saturate his inner being. Then he would be able to lay them before the brothers. Today we should follow Timothy’s example and lay before the saints the things with which we have been nourished by the Lord through the ministry. How wonderful the church life would be if we all did this! However, if we turn from the ministry and seek to produce something different, we may give place to differing teachings. It was not Timothy’s intention to teach anything different from what Paul taught. Rather, he would lay before the brothers what he had received from Paul.

At this point, I would like to say a word concerning my burden in putting out the Life-study Messages. The aim of these messages is to produce groceries for the local churches. My burden is not mainly to “cook” these spiritual groceries; it is to produce them and supply them to the churches that every local church may be a well-stocked supermarket, filled with a variety of nourishing foods. If the leading ones in a local church lay before the saints the riches contained in the Life-studies, the saints will be abundantly nourished. I have received many letters testifying that this has happened.

It is a fact of history in the Lord’s recovery that any church which follows the ministry is strong and blessed. But those churches which neglect the ministry and try instead to do something on their own have become a failure. However, in saying these things, I wish to make it very clear that I by no means insist that the churches or the saints read the Life-study Messages. To repeat, my burden is to produce groceries. The churches and the saints are free either to use them or to disregard them. But if the saints cast away the nourishment found in these messages, I wonder what they will feed on. We are what we eat. If we eat the “groceries” produced in today’s religion, we shall be part of religion. Let me say in frankness and honesty that the leading ones need to take “these things” and lay them before the saints that they may be nourished.

Paul’s expression “laying these things before the brothers” is very significant. We need to be impressed with the fact that this also is part of the Bible, the Word of God. I do not charge anyone to lay my words before the saints. It is not my practice to charge the churches to do anything. Representatives of hundreds of churches can testify that I do not charge them to do things. I do not even know many of the things that take place in the church in Anaheim, where I live. I am very glad that the elders take action regarding many things without letting me know. This is a strong proof that I am not a pope. Very much to the contrary, I am a little servant of the Lord, a farmer burdened to produce groceries for the saints. Far from charging the churches to do anything, I simply long that they feed on the spiritual riches the Lord has given us. Do not lay Witness Lee’s teaching before the brothers. Instead, present them the riches, the groceries, the Lord has shown us from the Word.

I am deeply burdened by the fact that many who love the Lord Jesus and seek Him have been deceived and frustrated. We must find a way to share with them the spiritual riches the Lord has provided us. Many who truly love the Lord are starving. We must take up the burden to supply them with food. We all need to be good ministers of Christ, serving others with His riches. Let us first be nourished ourselves and then minister this nourishment to all the people of God.

We would emphasize that being nourished is for the growth in life. This is a matter of life and it differs from merely being taught, which is a matter of knowledge. To minister Christ to others requires that we ourselves first be nourished with the words of life concerning Christ.

II. Being nourished

In verse 6 Paul specifically speaks of “being nourished with the words of the faith and of the good teaching.” The words of the faith are the words of the full gospel concerning God’s New Testament economy. The focus of God’s economy is not the image in Daniel 2 or the four beasts in Daniel 7. If you want to see the focal point of God’s economy, study the book of Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, and Colossians. We need to be nourished with the words of the faith, God’s economy, found in these books.

According to verse 6, we should also be nourished with the good teaching which we have closely followed. The words of the good teaching are the sweet words that contain and convey the riches of Christ to nourish, edify, and strengthen His believers. Actually, the words of the faith and the words of the good teaching refer to the same thing. If we would teach others, we ourselves must first follow these words closely. Following them closely and being nourished with them, we shall then be able to feed others. For example, if a mother does not know how to nourish herself properly, she will not know how to feed healthy food to her children. Through her own experience of being nourished, she will know what food is best for her children. This illustrates the fact that as good ministers of Christ, we must first be nourished ourselves with the words of the faith and of the good teaching which we have closely followed, and then we shall be able to nourish others.

III. Refusing profane and old-womanish tales

In verse 7 Paul goes on to say, “But the profane and old-womanish tales refuse, and exercise yourself unto godliness.” The Greek word for profane means touching and being touched by worldliness, contrary to being holy. If we would exercise ourselves unto godliness, we must refuse profane and old-womanish tales. Much of the teaching and preaching in Christianity today falls in the category of old-womanish tales. We should forget these tales and come back to the pure word of the Bible. In the so-called services among Christians today, there is a great deal of profane, secular, and worldly talk. People discuss politics and how to be successful in business. All this is profane talk, comparable to old-womanish tales.

IV. Exercising unto godliness

Refusing the profane and old-womanish tales, we should exercise unto godliness. Such exercise is like gymnastics. The words “unto godliness” mean with a view to godliness. Godliness is Christ lived out of us as the manifestation of God. This very Christ is today the Spirit dwelling in our spirit (2 Cor. 3:17; Rom. 8:9-10; 2 Tim. 4:22). Hence, to exercise ourselves unto godliness is to exercise our spirit to live Christ in our daily life.

In verse 7 Paul uses a Greek term referring to gymnastic exercise with respect to exercise unto godliness. We know from 3:16 that the mystery of godliness, God manifest in the flesh, is great. By our spirit with the indwelling Spirit we must exercise ourselves unto this goal, unto the expression of God.

In verse 8 Paul continues, “For bodily exercise is profitable for a little, but godliness is profitable for all things, having promise of the present life and of the life which is coming.” The words “a little” denote a few things to a small extent of our being, in contrast with all things. “All things” refer not only to one part of our being, but to all parts — physical, psychological, and spiritual — both temporal and eternal. The promise of the present life which is in this age is like that in Matthew 6:33; John 16:33; Philippians 4:6-7; and 1 Peter 5:8-10. The promise of the coming life which is in the next age and in eternity is like that in 2 Peter 1:10-11; 2 Timothy 2:12; Revelation 2:7, 17; 21:6-7. A promise like that in Mark 10:29-30 is both of the present life and of the coming life.

Once again, I would urge you to refuse all profane and old-womanish tales. Even talk about doctrines such as eternal security can be nothing more than an old-womanish tale. People may come to us after a meeting and say, “I have been to the meetings of the church a number of times. But I have not yet heard a message on eternal security. What do you think about this?” Others may want to discuss the seventh-day Sabbath. This also is to talk of old-womanish tales.

In applying the matter of old-womanish tales to the talk common among today’s Christians, I am following the principle established by Paul. Here in 1 Timothy the old-womanish tales probably refer to Jewish tales. Those with a background in Judaism were familiar with many tales. In the same principle, those who have spent years in Christianity also know many tales. Some come to us and ask about healing, speaking in tongues, prophesying, and even the lengthening of legs. I have known many persons who spoke in tongues but who did not exhibit godliness in their daily living. We must be a living testimony of those who refuse the old-womanish tales and who continually exercise themselves unto godliness.

It is of crucial importance that we exercise unto godliness. Inwardly we need nourishment, and outwardly, we should have godliness. From within we should be nourished with Christ, and then we should have a living which is the expression of God.

V. A pattern to the believers

In verse 10 Paul goes on to say, “For to this end we labor and strive, because we have set our hope on the living God, Who is the Savior of all men, especially of those who believe.” Because our God is living, we can set our hope on Him.

In verse 12 Paul says to Timothy, “Let no one despise your youth, but be a pattern to the believers in word, in conduct, in love, in faith, in purity.” Although Timothy was young, he was charged by the apostle to bear the responsibility of caring for the building up of a local church and appointing elders and deacons. For such a responsibility, he was charged not to be childish, but to be a pattern to the believers. He was to be an example in word, in conduct, in love, in faith, and in purity. He was to be pure, without mixture, in motive and act.

Verse 13 says, “Until I come, attend to reading, to exhortation, to teaching.” Here Paul does not refer to reading in the sense of study, but to reading aloud in public. According to the context, this kind of public reading may be for exhortation and teaching.

VI. Not neglecting the gift

Verse 14 continues, “Do not neglect the gift which is in you, which was given to you by means of prophecy with the laying on of the hands of the elders.” Here Paul speaks not of the gift which was upon Timothy, but of the gift which was in him. This was probably a teaching gift, according to the context of verses 11, 13, and 16. This may also be confirmed by 1 Timothy 1:3; 4:6; 5:7; 6:2, 12, 20; 2 Timothy 1:13-14; 2:2, 14-15, 24-25; 4:2, 5.

Paul’s word about the gift being “in you” indicates that the gift mentioned here is not an outward endowment, but the inward ability of life to minister to others. It is not a miraculous gift, such as speaking in tongues or healing (1 Cor. 12:28), but the gift of grace, such as teaching and exhorting (Rom. 12:7-8).

This gift was given by means of prophecy with the laying on of the hands of the elders. Laying on of hands has two functions: one for identification, as in Leviticus 1:4, and the other for impartation, as here. Through the laying on of the hands of the elders and the Apostle Paul (2 Tim. 1:6), the gift of grace was imparted to Timothy.

Literally the Greek word for elders should be rendered presbytery, meaning the body of elders, the eldership. The elders, who are the overseers (3:2), represent a local church, which is the expression of the Body of Christ. The laying on of the hands of the elders signifies that the Body of Christ participated with God in imparting the gift of grace to Timothy. This was not a personal matter; it was a Body matter.

Dealing with the Saints of Different Ages

Scripture Reading: 1 Tim. 5:1-16

The divine standard and the human level

At the end of chapter three Paul comes to the high point of God's economy. In 3:15 and 16 we see the divine standard. But in 5:1-16 Paul comes down to the human level. On the one hand, in the church life we must have the divine standard; on the other hand, we must care for matters on the human level. In 5:8, for example, Paul speaks of providing for our own relatives. All the instructions in this chapter are very human, normal, and ordinary. Nothing is special, miraculous, or supernatural. The whole book is written in the same principle. This is necessary for the church life.

The principle of presenting both the divine standard and the human level is found not only in 1 Timothy, but also in the Epistles of Ephesians and Colossians. In Ephesians Paul first writes concerning the church according to the divine standard. Afterward, on the human level, he writes about husbands, wives, parents, children, slaves, and masters. In like manner, in Colossians Paul first writes about Christ according to the divine standard. Then he speaks on a human level about family matters. In 1 Timothy Paul does not come to the human level directly. Rather, he comes to this level by giving instructions to Timothy. In 5:1-16 Paul tells Timothy how to deal with the saints of different ages. My burden in this message is to cover four points from 5:1-16.

Living a normal human life

First, all the instructions given here are presented in a very human way. We should never think that if we reach God's standard, we no longer need to be human. Some believers have been influenced by the false teaching that Christians should be like angels, that it is no longer necessary for them to lead a normal human life. Many monks and priests in Catholicism have a living that is abnormal. Furthermore, the requirement that priests and nuns not be married not only is contrary to humanity, but has its source in demons. According to Paul's word in 4:1-3, forbidding others to marry is a demonic teaching.

We all need to learn to be human. In fact, the more spiritual we are, the more human we shall be. If we would live Christ, we must learn to be human in a genuine way. When the Lord Jesus was on earth, He was very human.

To damage humanity is to ruin both the means and the channel created by God for His economy. The reason demons and fallen angels forbid marriage and command people to abstain from foods is that their intention is to destroy mankind. Thus, we in the church must be human and follow the standards of normal human living. Some have falsely accused us of not being human. We utterly repudiate these allegations. In the church life we definitely emphasize the proper humanity. I can testify that I myself live in a normal human way. If you examine my living, you will find me to be very human. I am not a "saint" or an angel; I am simply a human being. Furthermore, I encourage all the elders to be human. The elders should not help the saints in their locality to be like angels. We appreciate the angels, but we do not want to imitate them. Instead, we prefer to be human.

We should be human Christians. On the one hand, we have the divine nature (2 Pet. 1:4); on the other hand, we are normal human beings. The fact that we have the divine nature with the divine life does not mean that we shall ever be deified. Rather, we are to live a genuinely human life by the divine life and nature. In this way we shall be able to live the highest human life, a life like that of the Lord Jesus. When He was on earth, He lived a human life by means of the divine life and the divine nature. The Lord's human living was by the divine life. Our human living should be the same. Thus, we all must learn to be human.

In 5:1-16 we see that Paul instructed his young co-worker Timothy to contact the saints in a human way. Verse 1 says, "Do not upbraid an elderly man, but entreat him as a father." To entreat an elderly man as a father is surely to behave in a very human manner. In relation to brothers who are a generation older than they, the younger brothers should deal with them as fathers.

Paul also tells Timothy to entreat "younger men as brothers; elderly women as mothers; younger women as sisters." Timothy was not to assume an elevated position as a bishop, regarding himself as superior to others. On the contrary, he was to behave as a brother to younger brothers and sisters, as a son to a father, and as a son to a mother. In the church life there are many fathers, mothers, brothers, and sisters. To deal with the saints as such is to behave humanly.

Our contact with the saints must be in a proper atmosphere and with the right attitude and spirit. The atmosphere, attitude, and spirit in our contact with others mean a great deal. If a young brother assumes some kind of elevated position in relation to an elderly man, the relationship between them will be damaged. But if he would contact him as a son speaking to a father, their fellowship will be intimate, loving, touching, and even inspiring.

Suppose that in my relationship with the saints I conduct myself as a teacher and treat the saints as my pupils. If this is my attitude, my contact with the saints will be quite poor. But if I am very human in my relationships with the saints and regard myself as a brother among brothers and sisters, mothers and fathers, the contact will be loving and intimate. What a difference it makes when we are truly human in our relationships to one another! I repeat, in the church life we all must be human.

Exercising wisdom

In 5:1-16 we see in the second place that Paul instructed Timothy to exercise wisdom. His word not to upbraid an elderly man, but to entreat him as a father is a word of wisdom. It is a matter of wisdom not to rebuke sharply an elderly man. In dealing with saints of different ages, we need not only love, but also wisdom. We need to realize whom we are contacting. Are we speaking to an elderly brother or sister? Then we must speak to them as a son to a father or mother. Are we contacting a younger brother or sister? Then we must speak to them as a brother to a brother or a brother to a sister. Furthermore, we should speak one way to a father, another way to a mother, and in other ways to brothers and sisters. For example, in our human family we do not speak in the same way to all members of the family. We do not talk to our father in the same way as we do to our mother. If we speak the same way to all members of our family, we are indeed foolish. In all our relationships with saints of different ages we need wisdom.

If we exercise wisdom, we shall speak differently to saints of different ages. The brothers will talk to brothers in a way appropriate to brothers, but they will speak to sisters in a way appropriate to sisters. This is wisdom. We must not speak to a young sister in the same way as we do to an elderly man. Furthermore, one sister may embrace another. But a young sister should not show her love for a brother, young or old, by embracing him. Do not love the saints in a foolish way. Instead, always exercise wisdom, realizing whom you are contacting.

In all purity

Third, all our dealings with the saints must be “in all purity” (5:2). Every contact with the brothers and sisters in the church life must be pure in every way. We need to be pure in our motive and intention.

In the contact between brothers and sisters there is especially the need for all purity. For this reason, a brother and sister who are close to the same age should not talk privately in a closed room. Either another brother or another sister should be present. Consider the example of the Lord Jesus. He spoke to Nicodemus in a house alone at night, but He talked to the Samaritan woman out in the open during the day. This indicates that the contact between brothers and sisters must be in all purity.

In the church life the traffic in fellowship between brothers and sisters cannot be avoided. If we do not exercise all purity, we may fall into some kind of snare. Many have fallen into a snare because they were careless and failed to exercise purity in their contact with others. Therefore, we would emphasize again and again that the contact between brothers and sisters must be in all purity.

As we have indicated, our contact with all the saints, brothers and sisters, elderly and young, must be pure in every way. In speaking to an elderly sister as a mother, you need to be pure in your motive. It is evil to have impure motives. To have an impure motive means to seek gain for ourselves, to seek some kind of advantage or promotion. In our contact with all the saints in the church life we should have just one motive — to minister Christ to them that they may grow in the Lord.

Doing our duty

The fourth point I would bring out in this message is the matter of our duty. We need to be human, we need to exercise wisdom, we need to have all purity, and we need to do our duty. In the church life everyone must have certain duties to perform. No one should be idle or a busybody. In 5:4 Paul says, “But if any widow has children or grandchildren, let them first learn to show godliness toward their own household and to render a return to their parents; for this is acceptable in the sight of God.” Return here denotes requital, recompense. To render such a return is to show gratitude to one’s parents.

In verse 13 Paul speaks of those who “learn to be idle, going around from house to house; and not only idle, but also gossips and busybodies, speaking things which they ought not.” Some are idle, seemingly having nothing to do. But their idleness causes them to become busybodies. They go around from house to house gossiping and “speaking things which they ought not.” No one in the church should be idle, and no one should be a gossip or a busybody. Instead, everyone should have something to do, some proper duty to perform.

Realizing the need for all the saints to do their duty, Paul tells Timothy not to allow a widow to be enrolled who is under sixty years old (v. 9). He then tells Timothy to refuse younger widows, for they may set aside their first pledge, or faith (vv. 11-12). Setting aside “their first pledge” means to break a pledge or promise. This indicates that some younger widows promised, pledged, to devote themselves in their widowhood to some service of the church.

In verse 14 Paul goes on to say, “I will therefore that younger widows marry, bear children, rule the house, give no occasion to the opposer for reproach.” Childbearing and house affairs are a rescue and safeguard to idle busybodies. This is God’s ordination to restrict and protect women since the fall (Gen. 3:16).

Paul’s word in verse 14 about younger widows marrying is somewhat of a contrast to what he says in 1 Corinthians 7:8. The word in 1 Corinthians was Paul’s wish in his earlier ministry. In 5:14 we have his advice in his later ministry, according to his experiences concerning young widows. The difference here indicates that even in his God-inspired teachings, Paul was not legal. On the contrary, he could be very flexible. This indicates that, in the New Testament, concerning some matters there is no legality. In certain cases, the way we take may vary according to the actual situation.

Dealing with the Elders

Scripture Reading: 1 Tim. 5:17-25

In 5:17-25 Paul instructs Timothy concerning how to deal with the elders. The elders are the authority, or the government, of a local church. Thus, to deal with the elders is to deal with the authority, the government, the administration, of the church. For centuries there has been a debate among Christians over the kind of administration there should be in the church. In 5:17-25 Paul touches the crucial matter of the church's administration.

I. Elders counted worthy of double honor

Verses 17 and 18 say, "Let the elders who take the lead well be counted worthy of double honor, especially those who labor in word and teaching. For the Scripture says, You shall not muzzle a threshing ox, and, The workman is worthy of his pay." According to verse 18, the expression "double honor" includes material supply. Especially those who labor in word and teaching should receive this necessary supply. All the elders should be able to take the lead in a local church, but some, not all, have a special capacity in teaching. The word in verse 17 denotes the general speaking of doctrines, and teaching denotes instructions concerning particular things. Those who labor in word and teaching may be fully occupied, devoting all their time to this. Therefore, the church and the saints should care for their living. For this reason, in verse 18 Paul refers to what the Scripture says about not muzzling a threshing ox and about the workman being worthy of his pay.

II. An accusation against an elder

In verse 19 Paul goes on to say, "Against an elder do not receive an accusation, except on the word of two or three witnesses." According to the Greek here, the accusation made against an elder should not merely be verbal; rather, it should be put in writing. To make an accusation against an elder is a very serious matter. For the sake of accuracy, it should be put in writing and not merely be spoken. Furthermore, it should not be received except on the word of two or three witnesses.

Verse 19 is simple, but it implies something very important. The fact that Timothy was charged by Paul to receive an accusation against an elder indicates that the apostles have authority to deal with the elders after they have been appointed by the apostles to be elders. There is no doubt that the written accusation against an elder was to be presented to Timothy. Who, then, was Timothy? According to those who are in favor of a hierarchical system in which the bishops are over the elders, Timothy is regarded as a bishop. But as we have previously pointed out, according to the New Testament, bishops are elders, and elders are bishops. These terms are synonymous and refer to the same people. We know from 1 Thessalonians 1:1 and 2:6 that Timothy was an apostle. Furthermore, in the book of 1 Timothy we see that Timothy was the representative of the Apostle Paul. Therefore, for an accusation to come to Timothy was for it to come to an apostle. We would expect such an accusation to come to the apostles because they were the ones who had appointed the elders.

Some have had the concept from reading Brother Nee's book *The Normal Christian Church Life* that once apostles have appointed elders in a particular local church, the apostles do not under any circumstances have the right to interfere with the affairs of that church. This, however, is a misunderstanding of Brother Nee's word. In another book, *Church Affairs*, Brother Nee points out that after the elders have been appointed by the apostles, they should take the lead in the church according to the apostles' teaching. If the elders lead others astray or if they are wrong in some way, accusation against them can be made by the saints to the apostles.

However, an apostle is not a pope. If we read the New Testament carefully, we shall see that the elders are not appointed by anyone who is a dictator or who exercises autonomous authority. On the contrary, elders are appointed in the way of life. As the saints in a particular locality meet together to worship God and to serve the Lord, it will be manifested that certain brothers have a greater degree of maturity than others. Although no one will be fully mature, some will be comparatively mature. Not even in Philippians 3 did Paul regard himself as matured in full. Because maturity is relative, the qualifications of an elder are not absolute. In other words, an elder's qualifications are comparative. Among all the saints in a local church, certain brothers, by comparison, are more qualified and mature than others. These brothers are manifested as such before the eyes of the church, and all the saints clearly realize that these are the ones who should be appointed elders. This appointment does not come either by a vote of the congregation or by the exercise of autonomous authority. Instead, elders are selected according to the insight and foresight of the saints. Based upon the saints' insight and foresight, the apostles then appoint certain ones to be elders. The apostles minister the Word, bring others to the Lord's salvation, and edify them after they are saved; they also establish these believers as a local church. Therefore, they have the standing and the position to say that those who have been manifested as relatively more mature than others should be appointed elders.

In verse 20 Paul continues, "Those who sin reprove before all that the rest also may be in fear." The fact that apostles can rebuke elders who sin indicates that the apostles have authority over the elders. The expression "before all" refers to the whole church. A sinning elder should receive public reproof because of his public position. If an elder is reproved publicly, the rest of the elders will be "in fear."

Verse 21 says, "I solemnly charge you before God and Christ Jesus and the chosen angels that you guard these things without prejudice, doing nothing by way of partiality." The elders in a local church are God's deputy authority. Dealing with them is a solemn thing before God. Hence, the apostle solemnly charged Timothy before God, Christ, and the angels to do it in such a way that the chosen angels, the good angels with God's authority, may see that His authority is established and maintained among His redeemed people on earth.

Paul's use of the term "chosen angels" indicates that here he is dealing with administration, government, authority. The book of Daniel indicates that the chosen angels are authorities, representatives of God's administration. Paul deliberately uses the term "chosen angels" to indicate that here his instructions are related to administration, government, and authority in the church. Paul not only charged Timothy before God and Christ Jesus, but also charged him before the chosen angels.

Paul's charge to Timothy in verse 21 was to "guard these things without prejudice, doing nothing by way of partiality." To guard is to observe and keep. Prejudice refers to prejudgment, condemnation, before hearing the case, and partiality refers to inclination, favor, or bias. The words "without prejudice" imply without prejudgment to the credit of the accuser, whereas "doing nothing by way of partiality" implies no perverted favor to the accused elder. On the one hand, Timothy was not to take sides with those who made an accusation against an elder. To give them credit in a hasty way would be to show prejudice. On the other hand, Timothy was not to be partial, not to show perverted favor, to the elder against whom the accusation was made. Therefore, in handling an accusation against an elder, three matters should be observed: first, there must be the word of two or three witnesses; second, there should be no prejudice; and third, nothing should be done by partiality. No credit should be given privately to the accusers, and there should not be any perverted favor toward the one accused.

III. Laying hands on elders

In order to follow these instructions, Timothy was charged not to act in haste. Verse 22 says, “Lay hands quickly on no man, nor participate in others’ sins; keep yourself pure.” We have seen that laying on of hands has two functions, identification and impartation. According to the context of the previous verses, here the laying on of hands refers primarily to laying hands on the elders. This should not be done hastily.

In verse 23 Paul goes on to say, “No longer drink water, but use a little wine for the sake of your stomach and your frequent weaknesses.” According to the context, this verse implies that the condition of one’s physical health may affect his spiritual dealing with others.

In verses 24 and 25 Paul says, “The sins of some men are manifest beforehand, going before to judgment, and some also they follow after. Likewise also, the good works are manifest beforehand, and those that are otherwise cannot be hidden.” The word sins in verse 24 indicates that this verse continues verse 22. It explains that some people’s sins are manifest earlier and others’, later. Hence, we should not lay hands on anyone in haste. What is mentioned here concerning the judging of sins is a principle applicable both to man’s judgment and God’s. The words “some also they follow after” refer to the sins of others now being hidden, but later manifest, going to judgment later.

The implication of the apostle’s charge in these two verses is that Timothy should not approve a person hastily because sins have not been manifested, nor condemn a person in haste because good works have not been manifested. Often a person’s wrongdoings are concealed. It takes time for them to be exposed. However, sometimes a person’s good deeds are also hidden, possibly covered by false accusations and rumors. Time is also necessary for the falsehood to be dispelled and the real situation to be brought to light. Thus, we should not make a quick decision whether an elder is right or wrong. Instead, we should wait and allow time to expose the situation.

It is easy for us to make quick decisions and hasty judgments. But even though it is difficult to take time in matters such as these, we need to learn not to be hasty. The elders should follow this principle in caring for the church. They should not judge anything or anyone hastily. What they do should be with witnesses and without prejudice, partiality, or haste.

A number of times saints have come to me with accusations against an elder. My response always has been to say, “Let me pray and then have fellowship with some co-workers about this situation.” Because an accuser sometimes wanted a hasty judgment, he rebuked me and claimed that I took sides with the one accused. However, I did not take sides with anyone. Instead, I wanted to pray and have fellowship with others in order not to act in haste.

The church is very different from any worldly organization and also different from organized Christianity. The church is according to the Lord’s mercy and grace and under His authority. In dealing with the administration of the church, we must observe the four points of having witnesses and of acting without prejudice, partiality, or haste. Do not show prejudice in receiving an accusation, and do not show partiality in defending anyone against accusation. Instead, take time, pray, have fellowship with those who possess spiritual insight, and wait for the Lord’s leading.

Often elders have told me of the need for more elders in their locality. Usually they would recommend someone to be appointed to the eldership. Then I would ask how long the brother has been saved, how long he has been in the church life, and how much he has grown in the Lord. Then I would encourage the brothers to wait for another period of time and also to pray. As a result, many have learned that my practice is always to tell others to wait and pray. Actually, this is not my policy; it is the instruction of the Apostle Paul. After a period of time has passed and the leading ones in a certain place still feel that a brother should be appointed to the eldership and that, comparatively speaking, there is no one more qualified than he, I may recommend that he serve as an apprentice in order to be proved. This means that he will share the responsibility of an elder, but yet not occupy the position of an elder.

In dealing with the administration of a local church, we follow neither the way of dictatorship nor democracy. Elders are not appointed by a dictator; neither are they elected by a vote of the congregation. In the Lord’s recovery there is no such thing as an autonomous dictator. We do not practice dictatorship, but we do recognize the divine authority, the divine life, and the divine light. The administration of a local church is not according to the way of worldly government or organization. But in the church we have the Lord’s headship with the divine nature, life, light, wisdom, and grace. Therefore, we pray and wait on Him as we watch and observe the growth of the saints. In those very rare cases where there is ground for accusation against an elder, we do not act in haste. On the contrary, we wait and pray. We know from verses 24 and 25 that eventually a person’s sins or good works will be manifest. As the snow melts and exposes the rocks hidden beneath it, so either a person’s sins or his good deeds will eventually be brought to light. For this reason, we neither receive an accusation against an elder nor justify an elder in a hasty way. Rather, we would make sure that the accusation is substantiated by two or three witnesses and then we would act without prejudice, partiality, or haste. Furthermore, we acknowledge the Lord’s sovereignty and wait for Him to make the situation clear.

Many have accused me of being a pope and of acting like an autonomous dictator to control the local churches. In the Lord’s recovery today, there are approximately four hundred churches in addition to those in mainland China. About three hundred seventy of these churches have been established directly by the ministry in the past thirty-one years. I certainly do not control all these churches. Some people, however, may ask why the churches and the saints pay attention to what I say in the ministry. They listen simply because I feed them and minister Christ to them. We thank the Lord that, in His mercy, He has opened His Word to us and established the ministry of the Word among us so that all the churches may be supplied and that all the saints may be nourished. The Lord’s way to care for the churches is the way of supply and nourishment.

Very rarely is there any exercise of authority among us in the Lord’s recovery. I avoid the exercise of authority whenever possible. Even though I may have the standing in the Lord to say something, my practice is not to exercise authority. In like manner, rarely do the elders in the local churches exercise authority. Our desire is to care for the saints, to love them, feed them, comfort them, and encourage them. This is the proper way for elders to function, for we are not an organization, but we are an organic entity, the Body of Christ.

Dealing with Slaves and Money Lovers

Scripture Reading: 1 Tim. 6:1-10

In 6:1-10 Paul deals with slaves and with money lovers. In verses 1 and 2 he speaks concerning slaves. Then in verse 3 he suddenly refers to teaching differently and not consenting to healthy words. Then in verse 7 he begins to talk about the love of money. Apparently the dealing with slaves has nothing to do with different teachings, and the different teachings are not related to the love of money. Nevertheless, in 6:1-10 Paul put these things together. This is indicated by the word “if” at the beginning of verse 3 and the word “for” at the beginning of verse 7. The use of these words at the beginning of these verses indicates that they are a continuation of the foregoing verses.

In studying the Bible we should not be careless. Even little words such as “if” and “for” deserve our attention. Paying attention to words such as these often can bring in light. These words not only enable us to see the continuation in thought; they also afford a way for light to come in. Because by the Lord’s mercy we have received so much light from the Word, we can say that in the recovery we know the Bible in the way of life, light, and spirit.

In the United States today there are different kinds of theology. Certain seminaries teach modernistic theology, which denies the authority of the Bible and teaches that Jesus was merely a man, that His death on the cross was not for redemption but was merely an act of martyrdom, and that He did not rise from the dead. In the theology departments of some secular colleges and universities, religion and theology are regarded merely as part of man’s culture. However, in other seminaries fundamental theology is taught. Nevertheless, the standard concerning the truth is not very high. The highest standard of theology found among Christians today in the United States is that which has its source in the teachings of the Brethren, especially as those teachings were made popular by Dr. C. I. Scofield and his famous Reference Bible and correspondence courses. Although Scofield adopted nearly all the teachings of the Brethren, he rejected the Brethren way to practice the church life. The leading teacher among the Brethren was J. N. Darby. Anyone who calls himself a theologian but who is not familiar with the writings of Darby is not a theologian of the highest caliber.

In 1925 I wrote to Brother Nee asking him which book, according to his knowledge, would be the best to help me understand the Bible verse by verse. As a young believer, I was eager to obtain a thorough knowledge of the Word of God. I wanted to understand every verse of the Bible, from the first verse in Genesis to the last verse in Revelation. Brother Nee told me that the best help in knowing the Bible in this way was Darby’s Synopsis of the Books of the Bible. Eight years later he gave me a copy of this five volume work.

J. N. Darby and his contemporaries were great teachers of the Bible. According to history, the Bible was opened more to the Brethren teachers than to anyone who had gone before them. These Brethren teachers did not know the Word merely according to tradition or according to letters in black and white; they knew the Bible according to fresh light which came directly from the Lord. Having been enlightened by the Lord, they received the vision and the revelation of many truths in the Word.

Christians today often talk about the Bible in dead letters. Some are familiar with Bible geography and history; they also know certain elementary teachings. However, they may not have any light or revelation.

We have pointed out that it is possible for Christians to speak of certain Bible doctrines as if they were nothing more than old-womanish tales. For some, even the doctrine of justification by faith is a “tale.” For example, a particular Lutheran pastor in China fifty years ago taught justification by faith. Nevertheless, he himself was an opium smuggler. As far as he was concerned, justification by faith was nothing more than a “tale.” Concerning this matter, he was altogether without light or revelation. One day an elderly lady evangelist from Norway, who was very prevailing in the preaching of regeneration, stopped this Lutheran pastor after a meeting and asked him if he had been regenerated. When he tried to tell her that he had been regenerated, she said that simply by looking at his face, she knew that he had not been regenerated. This Lutheran pastor was insulted and so much filled with hatred for this lady evangelist that he plotted that night to murder her. But at that very hour the Holy Spirit enlightened him and rebuked him, and he repented and cried to the Lord. The next morning when this lady evangelist saw him, she looked at his face and said, “Praise the Lord, you have been regenerated!” Then in the meeting this pastor gave his testimony with great impact. This influenced hundreds of young people to be saved. The case of this Lutheran pastor illustrates the difference between knowing the Bible merely according to the black and white letters and knowing the Word according to the shining of the divine light.

Among Christians today there are many old-womanish tales. Not only are there “tales” about doctrine, but also “tales” having to do with so-called miracles. A certain Pentecostal pastor once told me about teeth that were supposedly filled miraculously with gold. Another Pentecostal minister claimed that in a certain meeting a person in the congregation miraculously spoke in Chinese. Both stories, however, were nothing more than “tales.”

The apostle’s teaching in 1 Timothy is far superior to old-womanish tales. Furthermore, in this Epistle there is no mention of miraculous things. On the contrary, in 5:23 Paul tells Timothy, “No longer drink water, but use a little wine for the sake of your stomach and your frequent weaknesses.” Here Paul does not exercise a miraculous gift to heal his co-worker. Instead, he encourages Timothy to be human, not religious, and to care for his health in a human way.

Many of those who teach the Bible do not have any light or revelation. They merely teach the Word according to the black and white letters, perhaps also giving out information about geography or history. Where can you hear a message from 1 Timothy 1:4 on the subject of God’s dispensation in the New Testament? By the Lord’s mercy, He has shined upon us and made known His truth. For this reason, I hope that reputable theologians and professors will study the Recovery Version and the Life-study Messages, even study them in a critical way. I believe that if they study our writings, they will receive light.

I. With slaves under the yoke

Let us now consider the logical connection between 6:2 and 3 and between 6:6 and 7. In 6:1 and 2 Paul charges those who are slaves under the yoke to count their masters worthy of all honor so that “the name of God and the teaching be not blasphemed.” The word blasphemed means ill spoken of, reproached. Furthermore, Paul charges the slaves who have believing masters to serve them in a proper way. Paul concludes verse 2 with the words, “These things teach and exhort.”

II. With money lovers

A. Teaching differently

Then in verses 3 and 4 Paul goes on to say, “If anyone teaches differently and does not consent to healthy words, those of our Lord Jesus Christ, and the teaching which is according to godliness, he is blinded with pride.” To teach differently is to teach things that differ from the apostles’ teaching centered on Christ and the church. The “healthy words” here refer to the health of life. The sound teaching of the apostles ministers healthy teaching as the supply of life to people. The words of our Lord Jesus Christ are words of life (John 6:63); hence, they are healthy words. The healthy words of the Lord are the source of the teaching according to godliness. When the Lord’s words of life are taught, particularly in certain aspects, they become the teaching according to godliness. The living words of the Lord always bring forth godliness — a life that lives Christ and expresses God in Christ.

Paul’s word in 6:3 concerning teaching differently indicates that even his teaching concerning slaves was according to the healthy words of the Lord Jesus. Paul’s teaching was according to godliness. However, because some did not consent to healthy words, they taught differently. They did not teach according to godliness. Thus, there is definitely a connection between verses 2 and 3.

All our teaching must be according to the healthy words of God’s economy. Even those who care for the children in the children’s meeting should teach the children in principle according to the healthy words of the Lord Jesus. This means that the children should receive teaching which is according to godliness.

B. Blinded with pride

In 6:4 and 5 Paul says that the one who teaches differently and who does not consent to healthy words is “blinded with pride, understanding nothing, but is sick with questionings and contentions of words, out of which come envy, strife, revilings, evil suspicions, perpetual wranglings of men corrupted in mind and deprived of the truth, supposing godliness to be a means of gain.” Teachings differing from the healthy words of the Lord always issue from people’s pride with self-conceit which blinds them. Paul and his co-workers taught in a certain way. But some who were blinded with pride deliberately taught differently. To them, it was humiliating to teach the same as others. I can testify that when I was in China, I was very happy to teach the same thing as Brother Nee. As much as possible, I even used the same terms Brother Nee used, for I realized that in this way I was carrying out the Lord’s ministry.

In verse 4 Paul uses the expression “sick with questionings.” To question and contend about words is a sickness. “Sick” here is in contrast to “healthy” in verse 3.

The word revilings in 6:4 literally means blasphemies. As in Colossians 3:8, it refers here to revilings, railings toward man, not blasphemies toward God.

We have seen that in verse 5 Paul speaks of “perpetual wranglings of men corrupted in mind and deprived of the truth, supposing godliness to be a means of gain.” The Greek for “perpetual wranglings” can also be rendered “incessant quarrels.” These wranglings are carried on by men corrupted and depraved in mind and deprived, bereft, destitute, of the truth. The Greek word for “deprived” implies that these are ones who once possessed the truth, but now it has been put away from them. Hence, they are destitute of the truth.

In verse 5 Paul refers to those who suppose “godliness to be a means of gain.” They make godliness a way of gain — material profit, a gain-making trade. The desire for material gain is another reason certain ones teach differently. Thus, because of pride and the desire for profit, for riches, some today are teaching differently. Pride is related to wanting a name and a good reputation, and gain is related to money and material profit.

C. Godliness with contentment

In verse 6 Paul says, “But godliness with contentment is great gain.” Concerning the expression “contentment,” Vincent says, “An inward self-sufficiency, as opposed to the lack or the desire of outward things. It was a favourite Stoic word.” The expression “great gain” means great means of gain. It mainly denotes the blessings in this age — godliness plus self-sufficiency and the ability to be free from greediness and the cares of this age.

Paul’s mention of gain in verses 5 and 6 brings him to the matter of dealing with money lovers in verses 7 through 10. For this reason, he uses the conjunction “for” to join verses 6 and 7.

Once again I would point out that because we pay attention to these details, we have come to know the Bible in the way of life, light, and spirit. We do not claim to know the Bible more than others do in geography or history. Neither do we claim the ability to recite more verses. But we can testify that by the Lord’s mercy and through the help of great Bible teachers who have gone before us, the Lord has shown us much light. The Lord has given us light, life, and spirit through the Word. The Psalmist once declared, “The entrance of thy words giveth light” (119:130). Furthermore, the Lord Jesus said, “The words which I have spoken unto you are spirit and are life” (John 6:63). We praise the Lord for giving us light, life, and spirit!

The Lord Jesus was raised in a carpenter’s home in Nazareth and was regarded as one who was unlearned. But there can be no doubt that He had tremendous light, life, and spirit. To have light, life, and spirit does not depend on one’s scholarship or degrees. On the contrary, our confidence in our education can hinder us from receiving light, life, and spirit through the Word.

In 6:7 Paul goes on to say, “For we have brought nothing into the world; it is evident that neither can we carry anything out.” This has been wisely ordained by God that we may trust in Him for our needs and live by Him in order to express Him without preoccupation or distraction.

Verse 8 continues, “But having food and covering, with these we shall be satisfied.” Although the word covering refers to clothing, it may include dwelling. To be satisfied is to have sufficient provision for our needs.

D. The desire to be rich

In verse 9 Paul says, “But those who resolve to be rich fall into temptation and a snare and many foolish and harmful desires, which plunge men into ruin and destruction.” The resolve mentioned here is related to the strong desire to be rich. This is the love of riches, not the possession of them, that leads the avaricious into temptation. Some are actually rich; others have only a strong desire for riches. This evil desire ruins and destroys them. Ruin here implies destruction, and destruction implies perdition, both temporal and eternal. Those who resolve to be rich fall into a snare, as into a net, and also into many foolish and harmful lustful desires, which cause men to drown or sink into ruin and destruction.

In verse 10 Paul concludes, “For the love of money is a root of all evils, which some having aspired after have wandered away from the faith and pierced themselves with many sorrows.” Paul says that the love of money is a root of all evils. He does not say that it is the only root. The Greek word rendered aspired after means craved for, longed for. Those with this craving have wandered away from the faith; they have been led astray from the contents of our belief, from the truth of God’s New Testament economy.

A Man of God

Scripture Reading: 1 Tim. 6:11-21

In 1:4 we read of God's dispensation, and in 6:11 Paul uses the expression "man of God." Hence, this book begins with God's dispensation and concludes with the charge to a man of God. God's desire is to produce men of God by dispensing Himself into those who believe in Christ. A man of God is one who partakes of God's life and nature (John 1:13; 2 Pet. 1:4) and thus becomes one with Him in His life and nature (1 Cor. 6:17) and thereby expresses Him. This corresponds to the mystery of godliness, which is God manifest in the flesh (1 Tim. 3:16).

Fleeing and pursuing

First Timothy 6:11 says, "But you, O man of God, flee these things, and pursue righteousness, godliness, faith, love, endurance, meekness." On the one hand, Paul charges Timothy to flee certain things and, on the other hand, to pursue certain other things. Timothy must flee the negative things previously mentioned in this Epistle. He should pursue righteousness, godliness, faith, love, endurance, and meekness. It is significant that Paul does not tell Timothy to pursue power, gifts, miracles, and theological training. Furthermore, as we shall see, in verse 12 Paul does not charge him to fight for his theology or to lay hold on the doctrinal knowledge he has accumulated. However, many Christians today pursue power, fight for doctrines, and lay hold on theological knowledge, and they charge the younger generation to do the same. They also promote natural gifts, talents, and abilities. But in 1 Timothy very little is said of man's ability. Concerning the eldership, Paul tells Timothy that an elder should be apt to teach. This refers to the ability to instruct others like a parent helping a child with homework. Paul's emphasis in 1 Timothy definitely is not on power, gifts, or natural ability.

Paul charges Timothy to pursue righteousness, godliness, faith, love, endurance, and meekness. Righteousness is a matter of being right with people before God according to God's righteous and strict requirements. If we would be those who carry out God's dispensation for the building up of local churches as the expression of Christ, we must pursue righteousness. We must seek to be right with God and man.

In the second place, we should pursue godliness, the expression of God. In 4:7 Paul told Timothy to exercise himself unto godliness. A man of God should not pursue power or miraculous gifts. Instead, he should pursue righteousness and godliness; he should seek to be right with God and man in order to be a living expression of God in every way. This is to live a daily life which manifests God.

In verse 11 Paul lists faith after godliness. Faith is to believe in God and His word and to trust in Him and His word. As we have pointed out, faith involves an organic union by contacting God through the Word and in the Spirit. Faith, therefore, denotes a living union. Instead of pursuing a great work, we should pursue the organic union with the Triune God.

In 6:11 Paul goes on to mention love. We should be those who love others by the love of God (1 John 4:7-8, 19-21).

Paul also speaks of endurance and meekness. We should pursue endurance, the ability to bear sufferings and persecutions, and also meekness, which is a proper attitude in facing opposition. It is certain that if we live a godly life, we shall suffer. The world opposes God. If we live God and also live out God, expressing Him, we shall be opposed and attacked by the godless world. Thus, we should pursue endurance, and we should also pursue meekness.

Fighting the good fight of the faith

In verse 12 Paul continues his charge: "Fight the good fight of the faith." To fight for the faith means to fight for God's New Testament economy. In particular, it is to fight for Christ as the embodiment of God and for the church as the Body of Christ.

Laying hold on eternal life

In verse 12 Paul also says, "Lay hold on the eternal life to which you were called and have confessed the good confession before many witnesses." The eternal life here is the divine life, the uncreated life of God, which is eternal. Eternal denotes the nature more than the time element of the divine life. To fight the good fight of the faith in the Christian life, especially in the Christian ministry, we need to lay hold on this divine life and not trust in our human life. Hence, in 1 and 2 Timothy and Titus, the eternal life is stressed again and again (1 Tim. 1:16; 6:19; 2 Tim. 1:1, 10; Titus 1:2; 3:7). To bring forth God's dispensation concerning the church in 1 Timothy, to confront the process of the church's decline in 2 Timothy, and to maintain good order in the church life in Titus, this life is a prerequisite.

We have been called to the eternal life of God. We were born of the human natural life, but we were reborn of the divine eternal life when we were called by God in Christ.

The words "confessed the good confession before many witnesses" may refer to Timothy's confession of the faith at his baptism. At that time Timothy probably confessed a good confession of the eternal life before many witnesses, as we all should do, believing and being assured that he had received the life of God.

Verses 11 and 12 are a marvelous summary of nearly the whole New Testament. A man of God should pursue righteousness, godliness, faith, love, endurance, and meekness; he should fight for God's New Testament economy and lay hold on eternal life. All these matters are essential aspects of the New Testament. In contrast, the beasts in Revelation 13 and the lake of fire in Revelation 20 cannot compare with these essential aspects. We today must fight the good fight of the faith. This means that we must fight for Christ as the embodiment of God and for the church as the Body of Christ. Furthermore, we must not merely fight objectively, but fight subjectively by laying hold on eternal life. We should not do anything apart from this life. We should speak to our husband or wife and to our children not by the natural life, but by the eternal life. Even in the matter of buying a pair of shoes, we should live according to the eternal life to which we have been called. As today's Timothys, we need to lay hold on eternal life.

In verse 12 Paul specifically says that we have been called to eternal life. No other book in the New Testament speaks of "the eternal life to which you were called." This is a particular characteristic of 1 Timothy. Do you realize that you have been called to eternal life? This eternal life does not mainly refer to blessings in the future. To be called to eternal life does not mean that we have been called to enjoy blessings in heaven. Eternal life should be our life today, a life for our present daily living. By our first birth, the physical birth, we received the Adamic life. But because we have been called to eternal life, we should no longer live the Adamic life, the natural life. Yes, we must be truly human, even Jesusly human, but not in our natural life. On the contrary, we need to live a human life by the eternal life. We have been called to this life, and now we need to live it.

I am deeply burdened concerning this matter of being called to the eternal life. I am especially concerned for those dear saints who have been distracted from the eternal life to which we have been called and who have become preoccupied with other things. We have been called uniquely to eternal life. This life, the divine life, is actually the Triune God Himself. Having been called to eternal life, we now should lay hold on this life, live this life, and have our whole being according to this life.

The charge to a man of God

In verse 13 Paul goes on to say, "I charge you before God, Who gives life to all things, and Christ Jesus, Who witnessed before Pontius Pilate the good confession." Here Paul describes God as the One who gives life to all things. This indicates that we must focus our attention on life. Every aspect of our Christian walk must be something to which God can give life.

Paul's concept in verse 13 is that God gives life and that when Christ was on earth, He lived the eternal life. He lived by the very God who gives life to all things. Then at the end of His journey on earth, He stood before Pontius Pilate and made a good confession. The Lord's confession before Pilate was related to His living by the divine life. Now we can understand why Paul charges Timothy before God and before Christ Jesus. He charges Timothy before God because God gives life to all things, and he charges him before Christ Jesus because He lived the eternal life and confessed it before Pontius Pilate. Therefore, Paul indicates that Timothy must be such a person; that is, he must be a man of God. Christ was truly a man of God, living righteousness, godliness, faith, love, endurance, and meekness. Now Paul charges Timothy to be the same kind of person, a man of God living by the divine life.

In verse 14 Paul continues, "That you keep the commandment spotless, without reproach, until the appearing of our Lord Jesus Christ." The commandment must refer to the charge in verses 11 and 12. The word appearing refers to the Lord's second coming. Paul charges Timothy to live the life of a man of God until the coming of the Lord Jesus. Then the Lord could speak well of Timothy as one who lived on earth as the continuation of Himself. I hope that at the time of the Lord's appearing, He will be able to say to us, "Faithful child, you have been part of My continuation. I lived on earth as a man of God. You were My continuation because you also lived the life of a man of God. You did not live by the natural life, but you lived by the eternal life."

In verses 15 and 16 Paul goes on to say, "Which in its own times He will show, the blessed and only Sovereign, the King of those who reign as kings and Lord of those who rule as lords, Who alone has immortality, dwelling in unapproachable light, Whom no man has seen nor can see, to Whom be honor and eternal might. Amen." The relative pronoun "which" refers to "appearing" in verse 14. The personal pronoun "He" in verse 15 refers to God the Father, according to Acts 1:7. Although the Father dwells in unapproachable light, we not only can approach Him in Christ, but we also can have fellowship with Him. We can approach the Father because we are no longer in darkness. He is in the light, and we are in the light also (1 John 1:5, 7).

A charge to the rich

In a very real sense, 1 Timothy concludes with 6:16. However, in verses 17 through 19 Paul gives an additional charge to the rich. Verse 17 says, "Charge those who are rich in the present age not to be high-minded, nor to set their hope on the uncertainty of riches, but on God Who affords us all things richly for our enjoyment." This word may be regarded as a supplement to 6:7-10.

The rich are often a source of trouble to the church. However, many Christian leaders today like to have rich people in their congregations. But we should not have any preference for the rich. The poor may burden the church somewhat, but they do not damage the church or ruin it. Rich people damage God's economy much more than do the poor. The New Testament even says that those who are poor, either spiritually or materially, are blessed (Matt. 5:3; Luke 6:20). Because Paul deals with God's dispensation concerning the church, he cannot avoid speaking about the problems of rich people. He charges them not to be high-minded, nor to set their hope on the uncertainty of riches.

In their fund-raising activities, many Christian leaders give glory to those rich people who donate large sums of money. But they often neglect those who give only a small amount. The leading ones in the churches and the co-workers should not have this appreciation of rich people. Brother Nee even had the practice of not spending time with the wealthy. He preferred to be invited to the home of a poor brother. In this matter Brother Nee's attitude no doubt was right.

Verses 18 and 19 continue, "To do good, to be rich in good works, ready to distribute, willing to communicate, laying away for themselves as a treasure a good foundation for the future, that they may lay hold on that which is really life." Doing good here refers to the ready distribution of material things to the needy and the willing communication with such needs. To be rich in good works is to be rich according to God's pleasure (Eph. 2:10), not only in material things. The expression "a good foundation for the future" refers to the next age (compared with the present age in verse 17), the kingdom age, when the overcoming saints will enjoy the Lord's reward. For this we all need to lay a good foundation in the present age as a treasure for us to enjoy in the future. Those who are rich in this age should use their riches in such a way that they lay away as a treasure a good foundation for the future.

In verse 19 Paul charges Timothy to encourage the rich to "lay hold on that which is really life." This life is the eternal life referred to in verse 12. Material riches are for the human natural life in this age, which is temporal and hence not real. If we do good with material things, we accomplish something for the real life, laying away a treasure for our enjoyment in the eternal life in the next age. This requires us to lay hold on God's eternal life, which is the real life. Otherwise, we shall lay hold on our human natural life in laying away a treasure of material riches for a life in this age, a life that is not real. We should care for the eternal life rather than for the natural life.

Both verse 12 and verse 19 stress the eternal life of God. This indicates that the divine life is the vital and crucial factor in our Christian life.

Guarding the deposit

Verses 20 and 21 say, "O Timothy, guard the deposit, turning away from profane, vain babblings and oppositions of what is falsely called knowledge, which some professing have misaimed concerning the faith." The deposit was that which was committed to Timothy and entrusted to him: the healthy words which he received from Paul not only for himself, but also for others. By "what is falsely called knowledge" Paul means the teachings of the false teachers, teachings which were called knowledge (probably referring to Gnostic knowledge). This false knowledge replaced the genuine knowledge of the healthy word of God which was entrusted to Timothy. Those who profess what is falsely called knowledge have misaimed concerning the faith. Concerning the objective contents of our belief, they have missed the mark, as in shooting. They have misaimed concerning God's New Testament economy. After giving this further word, Paul concludes by saying, "Grace be with you."